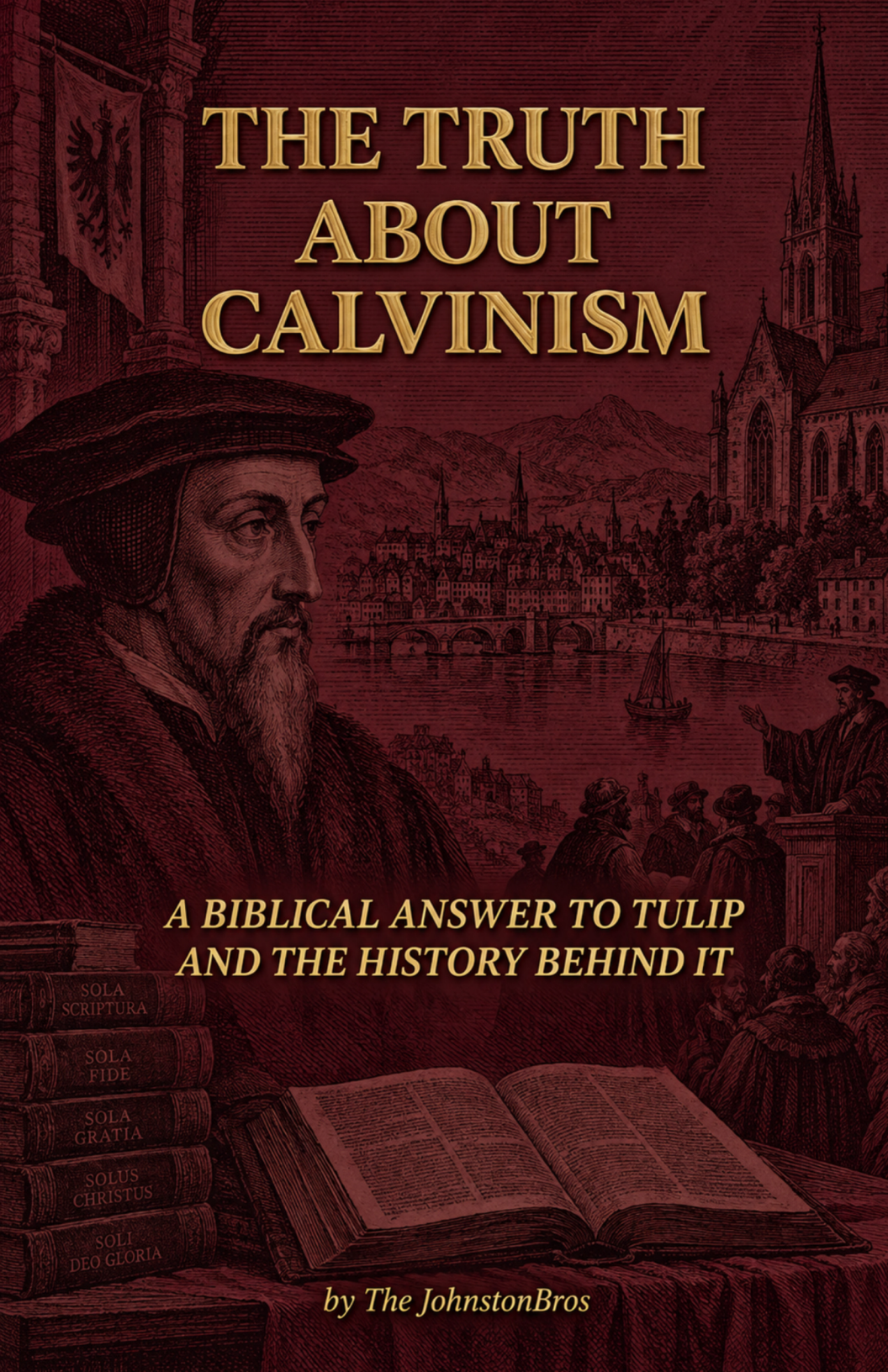
THE TRUTH ABOUT CALVINISM



A BIBLICAL ANSWER TO TULIP AND THE HISTORY BEHIND IT

by The JohnstonBros

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PREFACE

The doctrines examined in this book are sometimes treated as matters for the classroom, but their effects are practical and personal. Some who were taught that God chose certain people for heaven and others for hell before they were born, apart from anything in them, have found it impossible to love the God described to them and have left the faith altogether. Well-known preachers have told unbelievers that they cannot repent unless God first regenerates them, and in the same breath have charged them with guilt for not repenting. Local churches have divided over these questions. The system of doctrine behind these teachings is called Calvinism, and its influence in the evangelical world is greater today than many Christians realize.

This book examines that system. It begins with history, because the origin of a doctrine is relevant to its evaluation, and the history of Calvinism is not widely known. It then considers the five points of Calvinism one at a time, sets out what Calvinists themselves teach in their own confessions and writings, and compares each point with Scripture. We have sought to represent the opposing view fairly and to let the biblical text decide the questions. Wherever a church father, reformer, confession, or modern teacher is quoted, the source is given so that readers may examine it for themselves.

The authors are four brothers who have studied and debated these passages together for many years. We do not claim to have resolved every difficulty. We do claim that the Bible speaks clearly on the questions that matter most, and that where it speaks with authority, the authority belongs to Scripture rather than to us. Our hope is that believers who have been troubled by these ideas will come away assured that God is who the Bible says he is: a God who "so loved the world" (John 3:16), who is "not willing that any should perish" (2 Pet. 3:9), and who invites "whosoever will" to come (Rev. 22:17).

Readers who want to go deeper into the history and the original sources will find the most thorough documentation in Laurence Vance's study of the subject.[1]

[1]Laurence M. Vance, *The Other Side of Calvinism*, rev. ed. (Pensacola, FL: Vance Publications, 1999). Much of the historical material in the first chapters of this book can be traced in greater detail there.

WHAT CALVINISM TEACHES

Calvinism goes by many names. Some call it Reformed theology, some the doctrines of grace, and some Augustinianism. Presbyterian churches hold it officially, and it is found among many Baptists as well. Historically there were General Baptists, who held that Christ died for all, and Particular Baptists, who held that he died only for the elect. The labels change, but the system is the same.

At its heart, Calvinism teaches that man has no free will when it comes to salvation. Most Calvinists grant that people make real choices in everyday life, though even that becomes murky the further one presses. But in salvation, they say, a lost man is so thoroughly corrupt that he cannot turn to God on his own. God must choose him, regenerate him, and draw him irresistibly. Those God did not choose are left in their sin, and in the fuller form of the system, they were appointed to it.

The system is usually summed up in five points, and the five points are usually remembered by the acronym TULIP:

T, Total Depravity, meaning man in his fallen state is unable to respond to God.

U, Unconditional Election, meaning God chose certain individuals for salvation before the foundation of the world, not on the basis of anything foreseen in them.

L, Limited Atonement, meaning Christ died to save only the elect.

I, Irresistible Grace, meaning when God effectually calls one of the elect, that person cannot resist.

P, Perseverance of the Saints, meaning the truly elect will persevere in faith and holiness to the end.

The five points come from the Synod of Dort, which met in the Netherlands in 1618 and 1619 to answer the followers of Jacobus Arminius. Those followers, called the Remonstrants, had set out

five articles in 1610, and the synod responded point by point in its Canons. The acronym TULIP came much later. The earliest known record of it is a 1913 article recalling a lecture given around 1905 by the Presbyterian pastor Cleland Boyd McAfee, who used the word "to aid the mind in remembering the Five Points."[2] But the doctrines themselves are stated plainly in the Canons of Dort and in the Westminster Confession of Faith (1646), and we will quote those documents throughout this book so that Calvinism is described in its own words.

One Question Underneath It All

Calvinists often speak as though the five points stand together like five equal pillars. In reality there is a foundation. Everything rests on the first point. If a sinner can, in response to the gospel, call on God of his own will, then there is no need for an election that bypasses his will, no need for an atonement limited to the elect, and no need for grace that cannot be resisted. The Calvinist theologian R. C. Sproul said the same thing: "if a person really embraces what is called the doctrine of total depravity, the other four points in this five-point system more or less fall in line."[3] Sproul went so far as to say that a four-point Calvinist is really an Arminian, because the points stand or fall together.[4] We agree with him on that much. Knock out the first point and the rest cannot stand. The whole system comes down to one question:

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[2]William H. Vail, "The Five Points of Calvinism Historically Considered," *The New Outlook* 104 (1913): 394, quoted by the PCA Historical Center, "Originator of the T.U.L.I.P. Acrostic?" https://thisday.pcahistory.org/2013/09/originator-of-the-t-u-l-i-p-acrostic/. In McAfee's version the U stood for "universal sovereignty."

[3]R. C. Sproul, "Total Depravity (Part 1)," from the teaching series *What Is Reformed Theology?* (Ligonier Ministries), broadcast on *Renewing Your Mind*, May 12, 2025, https://www.truthnetwork.com/show/renewing-your-mind-rc-sproul/101577/.

[4]R. C. Sproul, *The Truth of the Cross* (Lake Mary, FL: Reformation Trust, 2007), 140–42, quoted in Justin Taylor, "Sproul on Four-Point Calvinism," The Gospel Coalition, October 29, 2017, https://www.thegospelcoalition.org/blogs/justin-taylor/sproul-on-four-point-calvinism/.

does a lost man have a genuine choice when God offers him salvation?

Calvinists frame the debate in two big words. *Monergism* means God alone works in salvation, with man contributing nothing, not even the choice to believe. *Synergism* means man cooperates with God. Calvinists call anyone who believes a sinner can choose to receive Christ a synergist, as if faith were a work. We would put it more simply. God does all the work of salvation. Christ paid for it all. But God offers that salvation to everyone and calls on them to receive it by faith, and a man can receive it or refuse it. Receiving a gift is not earning it.

An Overcorrection

It helps to understand why the system developed the way it did. The Reformers were reacting against Rome, which taught that man cooperates with God in salvation through works and sacraments. The Reformers rightly rejected salvation by works. But the Calvinist wing swung so far in the other direction that it said man cannot even believe of his own will. To Calvinism, faith itself begins to look like a work, and any human response looks like stealing God's glory. The Bible never treats faith that way, as we will see. Calvinism is, in many ways, an overcorrection to Roman Catholicism, and as we will also see, it never fully left Rome behind.

Why It Matters

Theology is not an abstract exercise. What a church believes about salvation determines what it tells a lost person who asks how to be saved. A well-known example shows the difference.

At the 2010 Ligonier National Conference, John MacArthur, the longtime pastor of Grace Community Church and one of the most respected Reformed preachers of his generation, described visiting a man who was dying of AIDS and who had been a leader in the gay pride movement. The man asked what he could do to be saved. According to Ligonier Ministries' summary of the address, MacArthur replied, "You can do nothing. But you

can beat your chest like the publican and say 'God, be merciful to me, a sinner.'"[5] The man prayed, and MacArthur later reported that he professed faith and spoke of Christ to those who visited him before he died.

We rejoice in any sinner who comes to Christ. The question is not whether that man was saved, but whether the counsel he received was the counsel of Scripture. When the Philippian jailer asked, "Sirs, what must I do to be saved?" Paul did not tell him that he could do nothing. He answered, "Believe on the Lord Jesus Christ, and thou shalt be saved" (Acts 16:30–31). Paul gave a command and a promise. The Calvinist answer is shaped by the system behind it. If God chose before the foundation of the world whether this man would be saved, and if Christ died only for those so chosen, then a preacher cannot tell a dying man that Christ died for him or that he will be saved if he believes. He can only urge him to seek mercy and hope that he is among the elect. Scripture gives the sinner more than that: "Whosoever shall call upon the name of the Lord shall be saved" (Rom. 10:13).

The system also affects evangelism. If the number of the elect is fixed and cannot change, the purpose of preaching becomes difficult to explain. Calvinists answer that God has commanded evangelism and that preaching is the means by which he gathers the elect. Yet God also "commandeth all men every where to repent" (Acts 17:30), and on the Calvinist view most men are unable to do so. The system repeatedly requires the reader to believe that God commands what he does not enable and offers what he does not intend to give. Later chapters return to this problem in detail.

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[5]Ligonier Ministries, "2010 Ligonier National Conference – John MacArthur (II)," June 18, 2010, https://www.ligonier.org/posts/ligonier-national-conference-john-macarthur-ii. MacArthur later reported that the man professed faith and bore witness to his visitors before his death.

WHAT THE CHURCH BELIEVED BEFORE AUGUSTINE

Calvinists often speak as if their system were simply what Christians have always believed. It is worth asking, then, what the church taught about the human will before Augustine. The answer is striking. The earliest Christian writers after the apostles, living in a world full of pagan fatalism, went out of their way to insist that man has a real choice and is therefore responsible for it.

Justin Martyr

Justin Martyr, writing around A.D. 150 to defend Christians before the Roman emperor, anticipated the very objection that predestination raises. "But lest some suppose, from what has been said by us, that we say that whatever happens, happens by a fatal necessity, because it is foretold as known beforehand, this too we explain." God foreknows, Justin said, but foreknowledge is not fate.

> "For if it be fated that this man, e.g., be good, and this other evil, neither is the former meritorious nor the latter to be blamed. And again, unless the human race have the power of avoiding evil and choosing good by free choice, they are not accountable for their actions, of whatever kind they be."[6]

That is the argument of this book, written more than two hundred years before Augustine was born. Justin saw that if God decides in advance who will be good and who will be evil, then neither praise nor blame means anything. He did not think foreknowledge required it. Neither do we.

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[6]Justin Martyr, *First Apology* 43, in *The Ante-Nicene Fathers*, ed. Alexander Roberts and James Donaldson, vol. 1 (Buffalo, NY: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1885).

Irenaeus

Irenaeus of Lyons, who had learned from Polycarp, who had learned from the apostle John, wrote in his great work against the heresies of his day: "If then it were not in our power to do or not to do these things, what reason had the apostle, and much more the Lord Himself, to give us counsel to do some things, and to abstain from others? But because man is possessed of free will from the beginning, and God is possessed of free will, in whose likeness man was created, advice is always given to him to keep fast the good." He went further, and applied it directly to believing: "And not merely in works, but also in faith, has God preserved the will of man free and under his own control."[7]

Irenaeus reasoned that God gives commands, counsel, and invitations because man is able to respond to them. That is the point this book will press against the Calvinist reading of Scripture in the chapters ahead. And Irenaeus said it about faith, not only about works.

The Greek Church

This was not the view of a few isolated writers. The church historian Philip Schaff, discussing John Chrysostom, the great preacher of Antioch and Constantinople, notes that Chrysostom was "a decided synergist," meaning he taught that man cooperates with God's grace, and adds, "But his synergism is that of the whole Greek church; it had no direct conflict with Augustinianism, for Chrysostom died several years before the opening of the Pelagian controversy."[8] In other words, before Augustine's controversies in the West, the eastern churches as a whole held that man's will has a real part in responding to God.

Schaff also notes that Chrysostom, trained in the school of Antioch, followed "the simple, sober, grammatico-historical

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[7]Irenaeus, *Against Heresies* 4.37.4–5, in *The Ante-Nicene Fathers*, vol. 1.

[8]Philip Schaff, *History of the Christian Church*, vol. 3, *Nicene and Post-Nicene Christianity*, 5th ed., rev. (New York: Charles Scribner's Sons, 1910), sec. 170.

interpretation, in opposition to the arbitrary allegorizing of the Alexandrians."[9] That contrast matters. Augustine inherited the allegorical method that came from Alexandria, and his system grew out of it. The plain, historical reading of Antioch produced no such system.

Tertullian and Origen

Justin returned to the subject near the end of his *Dialogue with Trypho*, explaining why God permits men and angels to sin: "God, wishing men and angels to follow His will, resolved to create them free to do righteousness; possessing reason, that they may know by whom they are created… and of ourselves we, men and angels, shall be convicted of having acted sinfully, unless we repent beforehand."[10] Men will be convicted "of ourselves," Justin says, because their sin is their own choice, and repentance is set before them as a real possibility.

The same conviction appears in the two most influential Christian writers of the third century, men who otherwise had little in common. Tertullian of Carthage, the first major theologian to write in Latin, argued against the heretic Marcion that man's freedom is the very place where God's image is seen in him: "I find, then, that man was by God constituted free, master of his own will and power; indicating the presence of God's image and likeness in him by nothing so well as by this constitution of his nature."[11]

Origen of Alexandria, writing in the Greek East, listed free will among the doctrines that the church had plainly taught from the apostles. "This also is clearly defined in the teaching of the Church," he wrote, "that every rational soul is possessed of free-

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[9]Schaff, *History of the Christian Church*, vol. 3, sec. 170.

[10]Justin Martyr, *Dialogue with Trypho* 141, in *The Ante-Nicene Fathers*, vol. 1.

[11]Tertullian, *Against Marcion* 2.5, in *The Ante-Nicene Fathers*, ed. Alexander Roberts and James Donaldson, vol. 3 (Buffalo, NY: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1885).

will and volition."[12] We do not endorse Origen's allegorical method or many of his speculations, and his testimony is not cited here as an authority on doctrine. It is cited as evidence of what the church believed. In Origen's day, free will was not a disputed opinion. It was, in his words, "clearly defined in the teaching of the Church."

When Latin and Greek writers from opposite ends of the Mediterranean, writing before Augustine was born, agree that the freedom of the will was part of the church's received teaching, the claim that Calvinism simply represents historic Christianity cannot stand.

Augustine's Own Admission

We have already noted that Augustine himself held the older view before he changed his mind. He later confessed that he had once thought "that faith whereby we believe on God is not God's gift, but that it is in us from ourselves." The fountainhead of Calvinism began where the earlier church stood, and he moved away from it in the heat of controversy late in his life.

None of this proves our case by itself. The fathers could be wrong, and the Bible is our only final authority. But it does answer the claim that Calvinism is simply historic Christianity. The historic teaching of the first centuries was that God calls, commands, and invites, and that man is responsible because he can respond. Calvinism is the newer teaching, not the older one.

[12]Origen, *De Principiis*, preface 5, in *The Ante-Nicene Fathers*, ed. Alexander Roberts and James Donaldson, vol. 4 (Buffalo, NY: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1885).

AUGUSTINE: THE ROOT OF THE SYSTEM

Calvinism takes its name from John Calvin, the sixteenth-century reformer of Geneva. But Calvin did not invent it, and his admirers say so. Loraine Boettner, whose book on predestination has been a standard defense of the system for nearly a century, wrote, "It was Calvin who wrought out this system of theological thought with such logical clearness and emphasis that it has ever since borne his name. He did not, of course, originate the system… Augustine had taught the essentials of the system a thousand years before Calvin was born."[13]

Calvin said so himself. In his treatise on predestination he wrote, "Augustine is so wholly with me, that if I wished to write a confession of my faith, I could do so with all fulness and satisfaction to myself out of his writings."[14] The Dutch scholar Luchesius Smits, who catalogued every reference, counted 4,119 references to Augustine in Calvin's writings, 1,175 of them in the *Institutes* alone.[15] Understanding Calvinism therefore requires understanding Augustine.

Augustine's Early Life

Aurelius Augustine was born on November 13, 354, at Tagaste in North Africa, to a pagan father and a Christian mother, Monica.[16] He later became bishop of Hippo, and so he is usually

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[13]Loraine Boettner, *The Reformed Doctrine of Predestination* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1932), chap. 1.

[14]John Calvin, *A Treatise on the Eternal Predestination of God*, in *Calvin's Calvinism*, trans. Henry Cole (London: Wertheim and Macintosh, 1856), 30–31.

[15]Luchesius Smits, *Saint Augustin dans l'oeuvre de Jean Calvin*, vol. 1 (Assen: Van Gorcum, 1957), 271ff., as tabulated in Graham Joseph Hill, "Augustine's Influence on Calvin, Luther, and Zwingli," https://grahamjosephhill.com/augustines-influence-calvin-luther-zwingli/.

[16]Philip Schaff, *History of the Christian Church*, vol. 3, *Nicene and Post-Nicene Christianity*, 5th ed., rev. (New York: Charles Scribner's Sons, 1910), sec. 178.

called Augustine of Hippo. His own *Confessions* tell the story of his youth, and he did not spare himself. In his sixteenth year, he wrote, "the thorns of lust grew rank over my head, and there was no hand to pluck them out."[17] His mother warned him not to commit fornication, but, he said, "These appeared to me but womanish counsels, which I should blush to obey."[18] At Carthage he took a mistress, who bore him a son outside of marriage.

Nine Years a Manichee

More important for our subject, Augustine spent nine years in the Manichaean religion before his conversion. "During this space of nine years, then, from my nineteenth to my eight and twentieth year," he wrote, "we went on seduced and seducing, deceived and deceiving."[19] Manichaeism was a Gnostic religion that taught a cosmic battle between good and evil, held matter to be corrupt, and divided its followers into two classes: the "elect," who lived ascetic lives, and the "hearers," who served them. Augustine himself describes carrying food "to those who were called 'elect' and 'holy.'"[20] A man who spent nine formative years in a religion of fixed classes, an elect and the rest, and a thoroughly corrupt world, did not leave all of that behind the day he became a Christian. The shadows of it can be seen in his later theology.

His Conversion

Augustine's conversion was unusual. Distraught over his sin, he sat weeping in a garden when he heard, he says, the voice of a child from a nearby house, chanting, "Take up and read; take up

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[17]Augustine, *Confessions* 2.3.6, trans. J. G. Pilkington, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, 1st ser., vol. 1, ed. Philip Schaff (New York: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1886).

[18]Augustine, *Confessions* 2.3.7.

[19]Augustine, *Confessions* 4.1.1.

[20]Augustine, *Confessions* 4.1.1.

and read."[21] He took it as a command from heaven, opened the book of Paul's epistles at random, and read the first passage his eyes fell upon: "Not in rioting and drunkenness, not in chambering and wantonness, not in strife and envying. But put ye on the Lord Jesus Christ, and make not provision for the flesh, to fulfil the lusts thereof" (Rom. 13:13–14). "No further would I read, nor did I need," he wrote.[22] Whatever one makes of that experience, it is not the pattern of hearing the gospel and believing it that the New Testament gives us.

He Changed His Mind

Augustine did not always teach what Calvinists now teach. Early in his Christian life he believed that faith was man's response to the gospel. Later he reversed himself. In one of his last works he wrote that he had once been "in a similar error, thinking that faith whereby we believe on God is not God's gift, but that it is in us from ourselves."[23] From then on he taught that faith is a gift God gives to the elect alone. In other words, the father of the system himself held the view we are defending before he adopted the view we are answering.

What Else Augustine Believed

If Augustine is the fountainhead of Calvinist theology, it is fair to ask what else he taught. The list is sobering.

He accepted books of the Apocrypha as Scripture, listing Tobias, Judith, the two books of Maccabees, Wisdom, and Ecclesiasticus among the canonical books.[24] He believed the Greek Septuagint translation was itself inspired: "the same Spirit who was in the

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[21]Augustine, *Confessions* 8.12.29.

[22]Augustine, *Confessions* 8.12.29.

[23]Augustine, *On the Predestination of the Saints* 7, trans. Peter Holmes and Robert Ernest Wallis, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, 1st ser., vol. 5, ed. Philip Schaff (New York: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1886).

[24]Augustine, *On Christian Doctrine* 2.8.13, trans. J. F. Shaw, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, 1st ser., vol. 2, ed. Philip Schaff (New York: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1890).

prophets when they spoke these things was also in the seventy men when they translated them."[25] He followed the allegorical method of interpretation that came down from Origen and the school of Alexandria. He was an amillennialist, teaching that the thousand years of Revelation 20 are the present church age and that "the Church even now is the kingdom of Christ."[26] That same view shaped his teaching that the church had taken Israel's place.

He taught that infants who die unbaptized are condemned. They "will be involved in the mildest condemnation of all," he wrote, but condemned nonetheless.[27] In another place he said that "the mildest punishment of all will fall upon those who have added no actual sin to the original sin they brought with them."[28] He exempted Mary from any discussion of sin: "We must except the holy Virgin Mary, concerning whom I wish to raise no question when it touches the subject of sins, out of honour to the Lord."[29] He defended the use of the civil power to compel the Donatists, a separatist movement many Baptists have long regarded as among their spiritual forebears, to return to the Catholic church. He lived as a monk and is credited with shaping the monastic tradition of the West. And he taught a twofold predestination, some to eternal life and some to eternal death.

The Father of Roman Catholic Theology

It is no surprise, then, that Rome honors Augustine as one of its original four Latin Doctors of the Church, with Ambrose,

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[25]Augustine, *The City of God* 18.43, trans. Marcus Dods, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, 1st ser., vol. 2.

[26]Augustine, *The City of God* 20.9.

[27]Augustine, *On the Merits and Forgiveness of Sins, and on the Baptism of Infants* 1.21, trans. Peter Holmes and Robert Ernest Wallis, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, 1st ser., vol. 5.

[28]Augustine, *Enchiridion* 93, trans. J. F. Shaw, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, 1st ser., vol. 3, ed. Philip Schaff (New York: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1890).

[29]Augustine, *On Nature and Grace* 42, trans. Peter Holmes and Robert Ernest Wallis, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, 1st ser., vol. 5.

Jerome, and Gregory the Great, and keeps his feast on August 28, the day of his death. The church historian Philip Schaff, who was no enemy of Augustine, wrote that "Augustine is also the principal theological creator of the Latin-Catholic system as distinct from the Greek Catholicism on the one hand, and from evangelical Protestantism on the other."[30]

The significance of this should not be missed. The same man is the leading theologian of Roman Catholicism and the acknowledged father of Calvinism. Roman Catholics claim him, and Calvinists claim him, and both are right to. Calvin was to Augustine what Augustine had been to Origen: the one who took an earlier system, refined it, and carried it forward. Between Augustine and Calvin, a thousand years passed in which Augustine's doctrine of predestination lived on largely inside the Roman church. Then Calvin brought it back to the center of the stage.

[30]Schaff, *History of the Christian Church*, vol. 3, sec. 180.

CALVIN AND GENEVA

John Calvin was born July 10, 1509, at Noyon in Picardy, in northern France.[31] His family was devout and well connected in the Roman church. His father destined him for the clergy and secured for him, "even in his twelfth year (1521) a part of the revenue of a chaplaincy in the cathedral of Noyon."[32] Calvin was on the church's payroll as a boy. Later his father changed course and sent him to study law at Orléans.

A Brief Conversion Account

Calvin said very little about his conversion. The one account he gave comes in the preface to his commentary on the Psalms, written late in life. There he says that he was "too obstinately devoted to the superstitions of Popery to be easily extricated from so profound an abyss of mire," until "God by a sudden conversion subdued and brought my mind to a teachable frame."[33] He gives no date, no gospel, and no account of believing on Christ, and historians still debate when it happened.

Within a few years, at about twenty-six, Calvin published the first edition of his *Institutes of the Christian Religion* (1536). That first edition was a short manual of six chapters. Over the rest of his life he expanded it until the final edition of 1559 grew to four or five times its original size.[34] It became the doctrinal foundation of the Reformed churches.

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[31]Philip Schaff, *History of the Christian Church*, vol. 8, *Modern Christianity: The Swiss Reformation*, 3rd ed., rev. (New York: Charles Scribner's Sons, 1910), sec. 69.

[32]Schaff, *History of the Christian Church*, vol. 8, sec. 69.

[33]John Calvin, "The Author's Preface," in *Commentary on the Book of Psalms*, trans. James Anderson, vol. 1 (Edinburgh: Calvin Translation Society, 1845).

[34]Schaff, *History of the Christian Church*, vol. 8, sec. 79.

Still Catholic in Many Ways

The Reformers broke with the papacy, and God used them to open the door for the Bible in the common tongue. But they did not come out of nowhere. As Schaff put it, "All the Reformers were born, baptized, confirmed, and educated in the historic Catholic Church… They never doubted the validity of the Catholic ordinances, and rejected the idea of re-baptism."[35] That is why they persecuted the Anabaptists, who insisted on baptizing believers who had been sprinkled as infants.

Calvin's view of the church sounds much more like Rome than like the New Testament. In the *Institutes* he wrote of the visible church as our mother, "since there is no other means of entering into life unless she conceive us in the womb and give us birth, unless she nourish us at her breasts, and, in short, keep us under her charge and government." He continued, "beyond the pale of the Church no forgiveness of sins, no salvation, can be hoped for."[36] He reduced the Roman sacraments from seven to two, but he still called them sacraments and taught that "Baptism is the initiatory sign by which we are admitted to the fellowship of the Church, that being ingrafted into Christ we may be accounted children of God."[37] He baptized infants, even though he could offer no clear New Testament example of the practice. He was an amillennialist like Augustine.

The Protestant Rome

Calvin's Geneva came to be called the Protestant Rome, and it earned the name. The city's laws regulated dancing, dress, meals, church attendance, and even the names parents could give their children. Books judged heretical were banned. Schaff, who admired Calvin in many ways, records the result plainly: "During the ravages of the pestilence in 1545 more than twenty

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[35]Schaff, *History of the Christian Church*, vol. 8, sec. 73.

[36]John Calvin, *Institutes of the Christian Religion* 4.1.4, trans. Henry Beveridge (Edinburgh: Calvin Translation Society, 1845).

[37]Calvin, *Institutes* 4.15.1.

men and women were burnt alive for witchcraft… From 1542 to 1546 fifty-eight judgments of death and seventy-six decrees of banishments were passed." His verdict: "It is impossible to deny that this kind of legislation savors more of the austerity of old heathen Rome and the Levitical code than of the gospel of Christ, and that the actual exercise of discipline was often petty, pedantic, and unnecessarily severe."[38]

Servetus

The darkest mark on Calvin's record is the death of Michael Servetus, a Spanish physician who had corresponded with Calvin and had sent him critical comments on the *Institutes*. Servetus held serious errors about the Trinity, and no one should defend them. But the question is what Calvin did about him. Seven years before Servetus ever came to Geneva, Calvin wrote to his friend William Farel on February 13, 1546: "He offers to come hither, if it be agreeable to me. But I am unwilling to pledge my word for his safety; for if he does come, and my authority be of any avail, I shall never suffer him to depart alive."[39]

When Servetus did come to Geneva in 1553, Calvin procured his arrest, served as the chief theological witness against him, and pressed for his death. Servetus was burned at the stake on October 27, 1553.[40] Calvin's defenders point out that he asked for the milder punishment of beheading instead of burning, and that is true. But a man who writes that a critic will not leave his city alive, and then sees to it that he does not, cannot be excused on the ground that he preferred the sword to the stake.

Calvin did not hide his part in the matter. During the trial he wrote to a fellow minister in Basel that when Servetus came to Geneva, "at my instigation, one of the Syndics ordered him to be

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[38]Schaff, *History of the Christian Church*, vol. 8, sec. 107.

[39]Schaff, *History of the Christian Church*, vol. 8, sec. 137, quoting Calvin to Farel, February 13, 1546.

[40]Schaff, *History of the Christian Church*, vol. 8, sec. 155.

conducted to prison; for I do not disguise it that I considered it my duty to put a check, so far as I could, upon this most obstinate and ungovernable man."[41] To Farel he wrote in August, "Spero capitale saltem judicium fore; poenae vero atrocitatem remitti cupio" (I hope that the sentence will at least be capital; but I wish the cruelty of the penalty to be lessened).[42] He wanted Servetus dead. He only wanted him to die by the sword rather than the fire.

There is a famous letter from 1561 in which Calvin supposedly boasted of having "exterminated" Servetus. We have not relied on it, because Jules Bonnet, the editor of Calvin's letters, argued that it is a forgery.[43] We do not need it. Calvin's authentic letters say enough.

Nor was Calvin alone. In Zurich, where Zwingli led the Reformation, the authorities threatened the Anabaptists with drowning, a cruel mockery of their baptism by immersion. Felix Manz was bound, carried to a boat, and thrown into the river Limmat on January 5, 1527. Schaff notes that "it is not known whether Zwingli really consented to the death sentence, but he certainly did not openly oppose it."[44] The men we are taught to admire as the great Reformers killed people who believed the Bible as we believe it.

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[41]Schaff, *History of the Christian Church*, vol. 8, sec. 149, quoting Calvin to Sulzer, September 8, 1553. Schaff states that "Calvin was responsible for this arrest, as he frankly and repeatedly acknowledged."

[42]Schaff, *History of the Christian Church*, vol. 8, sec. 150, quoting Calvin to Farel, August 20, 1553. The translation is ours.

[43]Jules Bonnet, ed., *Letters of John Calvin*, trans. Marcus Robert Gilchrist, vol. 4 (Philadelphia: Presbyterian Board of Publication, 1858), 434–41, "An Historical Calumny Refuted." Bonnet examined the documents and concluded that the letters were "the work of an impudent forger" (440).

[44]Schaff, *History of the Christian Church*, vol. 8, sec. 26.

Why the History Matters

None of this, by itself, proves that Calvin's theology was wrong. A doctrine must be judged by Scripture. But history shows us where the system came from and what kind of fruit it bore when its authors had power. Our own Baptist forebears did not come out of the Reformation; they were among those the Reformers persecuted. The Reformers bore the brunt of Rome's opposition and opened the way for the Scriptures, and God used their work. Yet alongside them, and largely unknown, were the Waldensians, the Anabaptists, and others who were carrying the Scriptures, preaching the gospel, and dying for it at the hands of both Rome and the Reformers. The great names were not always the true heroes.

When Calvinism is presented as simply what the Bible teaches, it should be remembered that it came to us through a former Manichee who became the father of Roman Catholic theology, and through a Reformer who never fully left Rome and who put a man to death for disagreeing with him. Then open the Bible and see whether the system holds up.

Calvinists sometimes present their system as the settled teaching of the church from Augustine to the Reformation, rejected only by a few dissenters. The history of the doctrine is more complicated than that. Even within the Augustinian tradition, the idea that God predestines some people to damnation was repeatedly rejected, sometimes in the strongest terms. When the full Calvinist system was finally codified at Dort, it was done under circumstances that should trouble anyone who admires it.

The Council of Orange

In 529 a regional council met at Orange, in southern France, to settle the controversy that followed Augustine's death. The council was thoroughly Augustinian on several points, and Calvinists often cite it with approval. It taught that the fall had so weakened the human will that no one can believe in God unless grace first moves him, and it also taught baptismal regeneration, which Calvinists and Baptists alike reject. It is not an ally on every question. But on the question of predestination to damnation, its conclusion could not have been more emphatic: "We not only do not believe that any are foreordained to evil by the power of God, but even state with utter abhorrence that if there are those who want to believe so evil a thing, they are anathema."[45]

A council steeped in Augustine's theology, only a century after his death, pronounced a curse on the belief that God foreordains anyone to evil. Calvin, a thousand years later, wrote that "some are preordained to eternal life, others to eternal damnation."[46] Calvinists distinguish between God's foreordaining men to sin and his foreordaining them to the punishment their sin deserves, and that distinction is a fair one to note. Yet the council's

[45]Second Council of Orange (529), conclusion, Internet Medieval Sourcebook, Fordham University, https://sourcebooks.fordham.edu/basis/orange.txt.

[46]Calvin, *Institutes* 3.21.5.

abhorrence of the idea shows how far the doctrine of double predestination stood from the mainstream even of Augustine's own heirs.

Gottschalk

In the ninth century a monk named Gottschalk of Orbais taught a strict double predestination: that God predestines the elect to life and the reprobate to death. The response of the church was severe. The church historian Philip Schaff records that Gottschalk was summoned before a synod at Quierzy in 849, "condemned as an incorrigible heretic, deposed from the priesthood, publicly scourged… compelled to burn his books, and shut up in the prison of a convent."[47] We do not defend that cruelty. Gottschalk suffered unjustly for his convictions, and the treatment he received is one more example of the medieval church's willingness to use force in matters of conscience.

What is instructive is the reasoning of his chief theological opponent, Rabanus Maurus, archbishop of Mainz. According to Schaff, Rabanus rejected double predestination "chiefly, because it involves a charge of injustice against God; it contradicts the Scriptures, which promise eternal reward to virtue; it declares that Christ shed his blood in vain for those that are lost; and it leads some to carnal security, others to despair."[48] Those four objections, raised eleven centuries ago, are substantially the objections this book has raised from Scripture: the doctrine impugns God's justice, contradicts the plain promises of the Bible, empties the blood of Christ of its universal value, and undermines both holiness and assurance.

The Synod of Dort

The five points of Calvinism were set down at the Synod of Dort in 1618 and 1619. Calvinists regard the synod as a landmark of

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[47]Philip Schaff, *History of the Christian Church*, vol. 4, *Mediaeval Christianity, A.D. 590–1073*, sec. 121, Christian Classics Ethereal Library, accessed September 27, 2026, https://ccel.org/ccel/schaff/hcc4.

[48]Schaff, *History of the Christian Church*, vol. 4, sec. 120.

orthodoxy, and its canons are quoted throughout this book as the authoritative statement of the system. But the circumstances of the synod deserve to be known. Schaff, himself a Reformed theologian, describes them candidly. The synod was composed of delegates who were already committed to the Calvinist position; the few Remonstrant delegates from Utrecht "had to yield their seats" to orthodox members. "Thus the fate of the Arminians was decided beforehand," Schaff writes. The Remonstrant leaders "were summoned before the Synod simply as defendants."[49]

The aftermath was harsher still. Schaff records that "the victory of orthodoxy was obscured by the succeeding deposition of about two hundred Arminian clergymen." The political leaders who had protected the Remonstrants had already been arrested. The scholar Hugo Grotius was condemned to perpetual imprisonment, and the elderly statesman Johan van Oldenbarnevelt "was unjustly condemned to death for alleged high-treason, and beheaded at the Hague (May 14, 1619)."[50] Schaff notes that the arrests were political and independent of the synod itself, and that should be acknowledged. But the fact remains that the five points were adopted by an assembly whose outcome was fixed in advance, and that their adoption was followed by the removal of some two hundred ministers who disagreed. A doctrine that must be established that way invites scrutiny.

Wesley's Protest

The evangelical revival of the eighteenth century produced another notable dissent. In 1739 John Wesley preached a sermon titled "Free Grace" on Romans 8:32, "He that spared not his own Son, but delivered him up for us all." Wesley argued that the

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[49]Philip Schaff, *The Creeds of Christendom*, vol. 1, *The History of Creeds*, 4th ed., rev. and enl. (1877; repr., Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Book House), sec. 65, Christian Classics Ethereal Library, https://ccel.org/ccel/schaff/creeds1.

[50]Schaff, *Creeds of Christendom*, vol. 1, sec. 65.

doctrine of unconditional reprobation "is a doctrine full of blasphemy," because it "represents our blessed Lord… as an hypocrite, a deceiver of the people, a man void of common sincerity." His reasoning was simple: "it cannot be denied, that he everywhere speaks as if he was willing that all men should be saved. Therefore, to say he was not willing that all men should be saved, is to represent him as a mere hypocrite and dissembler."[51]

Wesley's language was strong, and he himself warned his hearers not to accuse him of blasphemy for describing what he believed the doctrine implied. His argument, however, is the same one this book has made from the Gospels. The Lord Jesus wept over Jerusalem, invited all who labor to come to him, and said that he came to save the world. If he did not truly desire the salvation of those he invited, his invitations were not sincere. No Christian can accept that conclusion.

The Modern Resurgence

Calvinism is not merely a historical subject. In March 2009, *Time* magazine listed "The New Calvinism" among its "10 Ideas Changing the World Right Now." The article's author, David Van Biema, wrote that "Calvinism is back, and not just musically," describing it as "Evangelicalism's latest success story."[52] The movement's influence has grown through conferences, seminaries, study Bibles, and online ministries, and many young believers now meet Calvinism before they have studied the passages it relies on. That is one reason this book has been written. Each generation must test the doctrines it receives

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[51]John Wesley, "Free Grace," Sermon 128, secs. 23–24, in *The Sermons of John Wesley*, Christian Classics Ethereal Library, https://ccel.org/ccel/wesley/sermons.

[52]David Van Biema, "The New Calvinism," *Time*, March 23, 2009 issue, as quoted in R. Albert Mohler Jr., "TIME Magazine on '10 Ideas Changing the World Right Now,'" AlbertMohler.com, March 18, 2009, https://albertmohler.com/?p=3464.

against the Scriptures, as the Bereans did, who "searched the scriptures daily, whether those things were so" (Acts 17:11).

TOTAL DEPRAVITY

The first point of Calvinism is the foundation of all the others. The Westminster Confession states it this way:

> "Man, by his fall into a state of sin, hath wholly lost all ability of will to any spiritual good accompanying salvation; so as a natural man, being altogether averse from that good, and dead in sin, is not able, by his own strength, to convert himself, or to prepare himself thereunto."[53]

The Canons of Dort say that all men are "incapable of any saving good, prone to evil, dead in sin, and in bondage thereto; and, without the regenerating grace of the Holy Spirit, they are neither able nor willing to return to God."[54]

Depravity Is Not the Issue

At first this sounds like something every Bible believer holds. We believe man is a sinner. We believe that "all have sinned, and come short of the glory of God" (Rom. 3:23), that the heart is "deceitful above all things, and desperately wicked" (Jer. 17:9), and that in our flesh "dwelleth no good thing" (Rom. 7:18). Some Baptists even say, "I suppose I am partly a Calvinist; I believe in total depravity." But they do not, if they understand what the term means. The Calvinist does not simply mean that man is sinful. He means that man is *unable*. Total depravity is really total inability: a lost man cannot believe the gospel unless God first regenerates him. In Calvinism, regeneration comes before faith.

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[53]Westminster Confession of Faith 9.3, in Philip Schaff, ed., *The Creeds of Christendom*, vol. 3, *The Evangelical Protestant Creeds*, 4th ed., rev. and enl. (1877; repr., Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Book House), Christian Classics Ethereal Library, https://ccel.org/ccel/schaff/creeds3.

[54]Canons of the Synod of Dort (1618–1619), Third and Fourth Heads of Doctrine, art. 3, in Schaff, *Creeds of Christendom*, vol. 3.

Calvinists often illustrate it with a lion. Put a steak and a salad in front of a lion, and the lion is free to choose either one, but because of its nature it will always choose the steak. So, they say, a sinner is free to choose God, but because of his nature he never will. That is an analogy, not a Bible verse, and the Bible does not describe lost men that way. It describes lost men being called, commanded, and pleaded with to turn, and it describes some of them turning.

The Proof Texts

The verses Calvinists use for total depravity are real verses, and we believe every one of them. "There is none righteous, no, not one: There is none that understandeth, there is none that seeketh after God" (Rom. 3:10–11). "The carnal mind is enmity against God… So then they that are in the flesh cannot please God" (Rom. 8:7–8). "No man can come to me, except the Father which hath sent me draw him" (John 6:44). "And you hath he quickened, who were dead in trespasses and sins" (Eph. 2:1). "But the natural man receiveth not the things of the Spirit of God: for they are foolishness unto him: neither can he know them, because they are spiritually discerned" (1 Cor. 2:14).

Each of these verses should be read carefully with one question in mind: does it say that, for this reason, a lost man cannot respond when God calls him? Romans 3 says no one seeks God on his own initiative. It does not say no one can respond when God seeks him. Romans 8 says the flesh cannot please God. It does not say a sinner cannot believe. First Corinthians 2 says the natural man cannot understand spiritual things. Paul is talking about the deep things of God that the Spirit reveals to believers, not about whether a lost man can understand that he is a sinner and that Christ died for him. When a Calvinist quotes these verses, he adds the conclusion. It is not in the text. We must have missed the part of the verse that says "therefore he cannot believe."

Seek Ye the LORD

If lost men are truly unable to seek God, then God's own commands make no sense. "Seek ye the LORD while he may be found, call ye upon him while he is near: Let the wicked forsake his way, and the unrighteous man his thoughts: and let him return unto the LORD, and he will have mercy upon him" (Isa. 55:6–7). "For thus saith the LORD unto the house of Israel, Seek ye me, and ye shall live" (Amos 5:4). "Seek ye the LORD, all ye meek of the earth" (Zeph. 2:3). "And ye shall seek me, and find me, when ye shall search for me with all your heart" (Jer. 29:13).

The New Testament is the same. "The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand: repent ye, and believe the gospel" (Mark 1:15). "And the times of this ignorance God winked at; but now commandeth all men every where to repent" (Acts 17:30). "Look unto me, and be ye saved, all the ends of the earth" (Isa. 45:22). "Come unto me, all ye that labour and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest" (Matt. 11:28). "If any man thirst, let him come unto me, and drink" (John 7:37). "And the Spirit and the bride say, Come. And let him that heareth say, Come. And let him that is athirst come. And whosoever will, let him take the water of life freely" (Rev. 22:17).

Calvinists have an answer for all of these. They say those who seek were first drawn by God, and those who do not seek were never able to. This answer carries a heavy cost. Every *whosoever* must mean the elect. Every *all men* must mean the elect. Every *world* must mean the elect. The only way to make the system fit is to change the words God used. When the Lord said to the Jews, "And ye will not come to me, that ye might have life" (John 5:40), he did not say they could not come. He said they would not.

Seekers Before They Were Saved

The Bible gives us real examples of lost people seeking God before they were saved. Cornelius was a Roman centurion, "A devout man, and one that feared God with all his house, which

gave much alms to the people, and prayed to God alway" (Acts 10:2). He was not yet saved. The angel told him to send for Peter, "Who shall tell thee words, whereby thou and all thy house shall be saved" (Acts 11:14). Yet God heard his prayers and sent him the gospel. Peter drew the lesson: "Of a truth I perceive that God is no respecter of persons: But in every nation he that feareth him, and worketh righteousness, is accepted with him" (Acts 10:34–35).

The Jews of Berea were another example. "These were more noble than those in Thessalonica, in that they received the word with all readiness of mind, and searched the scriptures daily, whether those things were so. Therefore many of them believed" (Acts 17:11–12). The order is significant: they searched the Scriptures, and *therefore* they believed. Luke credits their readiness of mind and their searching, and he calls it noble. In the Calvinist order, regeneration must come first and searching second. Luke gives it the other way around.

God has not left anyone without a witness. "For the invisible things of him from the creation of the world are clearly seen, being understood by the things that are made, even his eternal power and Godhead; so that they are without excuse" (Rom. 1:20). Christ is "the true Light, which lighteth every man that cometh into the world" (John 1:9). Men are without excuse precisely because they could have responded to the light they were given. If they could not respond, they would have every excuse. We believe that anyone who truly seeks the truth will be given the gospel, as Cornelius was. God sends the message to the seeker.

The Drawing of John 6

The most important proof text is John 6:44: "No man can come to me, except the Father which hath sent me draw him: and I will raise him up at the last day." Reformed teachers regard this verse as decisive, and on one point we agree: no one can come to Christ unless God draws him. The question is whom God draws.

John answers that question himself. Six chapters later, the Lord said, "And I, if I be lifted up from the earth, will draw all men unto me" (John 12:32). Christ was lifted up on the cross, and therefore he draws all men. Every person who has ever heard the gospel has been drawn. The Calvinist must say that "all men" here means "all the elect," but that is not what the text says. God's drawing is real and universal, yet it can be resisted, as later chapters will show.

Read the Whole Chapter

John 6 itself does not support the Calvinist reading when the whole chapter is read. The Lord says, "All that the Father giveth me shall come to me; and him that cometh to me I will in no wise cast out" (John 6:37). And he explains who is given: "And this is the will of him that sent me, that every one which seeth the Son, and believeth on him, may have everlasting life: and I will raise him up at the last day" (John 6:40). The Father's will is that *every one* who sees the Son and believes on him should have life.

Then he explains how the Father draws: "It is written in the prophets, And they shall be all taught of God. Every man therefore that hath heard, and hath learned of the Father, cometh unto me" (John 6:45). The drawing is by teaching. God draws men by his word, and "they shall be all taught of God." Those who hear and learn come to Christ. Those who hear and refuse to learn do not. Later in the chapter the Lord says, "But there are some of you that believe not. For Jesus knew from the beginning who they were that believed not, and who should betray him" (John 6:64). He knew. Foreknowledge again, not force.

The audience must also be considered. These were Jews who had followed him for loaves and fish and who were murmuring against him. In the Gospels, the Father gave to the Son those Israelites who already believed God's word through Moses. "For had ye believed Moses, ye would have believed me: for he wrote of me" (John 5:46). The believing remnant of Israel came to Christ when he appeared. The unbelieving majority did not.

That is the setting of "no man can come to me, except the Father which hath sent me draw him."

Dead in Sins

Calvinists also argue from the word *dead*. A dead man cannot do anything, they say. He cannot hear, choose, or believe. On this reasoning, a sinner dead in sins cannot believe until God makes him alive.

But the Bible uses death in more than one way. Believers are also called dead: "How shall we, that are dead to sin, live any longer therein?" (Rom. 6:2). "For ye are dead, and your life is hid with Christ in God" (Col. 3:3). If *dead* means unable to make any decision, then believers cannot make decisions either. The Lord's own parable settles it. Of the prodigal son the father said, "For this my son was dead, and is alive again; he was lost, and is found" (Luke 15:24). Yet while he was "dead," the prodigal "came to himself" and said, "I will arise and go to my father" (Luke 15:17–18). Spiritual death in the Bible is separation from God. It is not the inability to hear God's call.

The same problem attends the other analogies Calvinists use. They say salvation is a new birth, and a baby contributes nothing to its birth. They say the believer is a new creature, and a creature contributes nothing to its creation. But analogies are not doctrines. In natural birth, conception and birth are separated by months, and the person did not exist before conception. In the new birth, the person who is born again already existed as a responsible human being who heard the gospel and believed it. The Bible says so: "But as many as received him, to them gave he power to become the sons of God, even to them that believe on his name" (John 1:12). Receiving comes before becoming a son. In John's order, faith is not the result of the new birth. It is the way into it.

A Good Tree and a Corrupt Tree

Another text often used is Matthew 7:18: "A good tree cannot bring forth evil fruit, neither can a corrupt tree bring forth good

fruit." A lost man is a corrupt tree, they say, and so he cannot produce the good fruit of faith. But the Lord was speaking about false prophets and how to recognize them by their fruit (Matt. 7:15–16). He was not describing the mechanics of conversion. And the Bible records lost men doing good things and saved men doing terrible things. If the analogy were a rule without exceptions, a good tree could never bring forth evil fruit either, and every believer would be sinless. The Lord's words are true in their context. They are not a doctrine of inability.

Faith Is Not a Work

Underneath total depravity lies the idea that if a man believes by his own will, he has contributed a work to his salvation and has something to boast about. The Bible teaches exactly the opposite. It sets faith and works against each other. "Where is boasting then? It is excluded. By what law? of works? Nay: but by the law of faith. Therefore we conclude that a man is justified by faith without the deeds of the law" (Rom. 3:27–28). "But to him that worketh not, but believeth on him that justifieth the ungodly, his faith is counted for righteousness" (Rom. 4:5). "Received ye the Spirit by the works of the law, or by the hearing of faith?" (Gal. 3:2).

"To him that worketh not, but believeth." God himself defines faith as the opposite of working. The Calvinist may call faith a work, but the Bible does not. If someone offers you a gift that he has paid for in full, taking it does not mean you earned it. God paid for salvation completely. We receive it. That is not boasting. That is the only way anyone has ever been saved.

Calvin himself agreed on one key verse. Calvinists often quote Ephesians 2:8, "For by grace are ye saved through faith; and that not of yourselves: it is the gift of God," to prove that faith is a gift given only to the elect. Calvin rejected that reading:

> "Many persons restrict the word gift to faith alone. But Paul is only repeating in other words the former sentiment. His meaning is, not that faith is the gift of

> God, but that salvation is given to us by God, or, that we obtain it by the gift of God."[55]

In the Greek the word for "that" (*touto*) is neuter, while "faith" (*pistis*) is feminine; "that" points back to the whole matter of being saved by grace through faith. Salvation is the gift. Faith receives it.

The pattern goes back to the beginning. Abel brought a lamb by faith, and Cain brought the fruit of his own labor (Gen. 4:3–5; Heb. 11:4). And before there was any sin at all, God put a tree in the garden and gave Adam a genuine choice (Gen. 2:16–17). Calvinists answer that Adam and Eve were not yet depraved, so their choice does not count. But God kept offering choices after the fall. "I call heaven and earth to record this day against you, that I have set before you life and death, blessing and cursing: therefore choose life, that both thou and thy seed may live" (Deut. 30:19). "Choose you this day whom ye will serve" (Josh. 24:15). The Bible nowhere says that man had free will until he sinned and then lost it. God has always dealt with men as responsible creatures who can choose.

The Evangelist's Dilemma

Consider a Calvinist preacher calling people to repent on a street corner. A man says to him, "You believe I cannot repent unless God first regenerates me. So if I do not repent, it is because God has not regenerated me." The preacher answers, "You are morally obligated to repent. You just do not want to. You hate God." Then ask him directly: If I repent right now, who took the first step, me or God? If he is honest, he must say that God regenerated me first and then I repented. Then the lost man is right. He cannot repent unless God moves first, and if God has not moved, the failure is not in the man's will; it is in God's decision. The preacher is calling men to do what his own

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[55]John Calvin, *Commentaries on the Epistles of Paul to the Galatians and Ephesians*, trans. William Pringle (Edinburgh: Calvin Translation Society, 1854), comment on Eph. 2:8.

theology says they cannot do. The Bible never puts us in that contradiction. When the jailer asked, "Sirs, what must I do to be saved?" Paul did not tell him to wait and see whether he was elect. He said, "Believe on the Lord Jesus Christ, and thou shalt be saved" (Acts 16:30–31).

UNCONDITIONAL ELECTION

If man is unable to come to God, then the only way anyone can be saved is for God to choose him first. That is the second point of Calvinism. The Canons of Dort define it this way: "Election is the unchangeable purpose of God, whereby, before the foundation of the world, he hath, out of mere grace, according to the sovereign good pleasure of his own will, chosen, from the whole human race… a certain number of persons to redemption in Christ."[56] The number is fixed, and the choice is made without regard to anything God foresaw in the person, including his faith.

Calvin did not stop at election to life. He wrote, "By predestination we mean the eternal decree of God, by which he determined with himself whatever he wished to happen with regard to every man. All are not created on equal terms, but some are preordained to eternal life, others to eternal damnation."[57] The Westminster Confession says that "some men and angels are predestinated unto everlasting life, and others foreordained to everlasting death."[58] Calvin himself admitted what this meant. Speaking of the fall of Adam and its consequences for whole nations and their children, he wrote, "The decree, I admit, is dreadful."[59]

Put simply, before the world began, based on nothing you would ever do or believe, God chose some people for heaven and passed by the rest, and nothing can change it. From a human standpoint such a choice appears arbitrary. Calvinists reject that description, but it is difficult to see how an election with no conditions whatever could appear otherwise.

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[56]Canons of Dort, First Head of Doctrine, art. 7, in Schaff, *Creeds of Christendom*, vol. 3.

[57]Calvin, *Institutes* 3.21.5.

[58]Westminster Confession of Faith 3.3, in Schaff, *Creeds of Christendom*, vol. 3.

[59]Calvin, *Institutes* 3.23.7.

Election Is a Bible Word

We want to be clear: election is a biblical doctrine. The Bible uses the word, and we believe it. The question is what the Bible means by it, and whom it says God has elected.

The Bible calls four groups elect. The Lord Jesus is God's elect: "Behold my servant, whom I uphold; mine elect, in whom my soul delighteth" (Isa. 42:1). Israel is God's elect: "For Jacob my servant's sake, and Israel mine elect" (Isa. 45:4). The church is elect: "Put on therefore, as the elect of God, holy and beloved" (Col. 3:12). And there are "the elect angels" (1 Tim. 5:21). Apart from Christ himself, the elect in the Bible are groups. Election in Scripture is overwhelmingly corporate. And the elect groups are not all the same group, so the context must always tell us which one is meant.

Ephesians 1

The chief proof text for unconditional election is Ephesians 1:

Ephesians 1:1, 4–5

"Paul, an apostle of Jesus Christ by the will of God, to the saints which are at Ephesus, and to the faithful in Christ Jesus… According as he hath chosen us in him before the foundation of the world, that we should be holy and without blame before him in love: Having predestinated us unto the adoption of children by Jesus Christ to himself, according to the good pleasure of his will."

The passage should be read carefully. First, Paul is writing to "the saints which are at Ephesus, and to the faithful in Christ Jesus." He is addressing people who are already saved. Second, they were chosen "in him." The choosing is in Christ. God chose a body, those who would be in Christ, and every sinner who believes is placed into that body. Third, look at what they were chosen *to*: "that we should be holy and without blame before him in love." Holiness and blamelessness are words of sanctification, not of initial salvation. Paul does not say God chose some individuals to be saved and others to be lost. He says

God chose those in Christ to be holy. Fourth, the predestination is "unto the adoption of children," which Paul elsewhere calls "the redemption of our body" (Rom. 8:23), the future completion of our salvation.

Romans 8:29 says the same: "For whom he did foreknow, he did also predestinate to be conformed to the image of his Son." Predestination in the Bible is not God deciding who will believe. It is God deciding what will become of those who believe: they will be conformed to the image of Christ. Peter speaks the same way: "Elect according to the foreknowledge of God the Father, through sanctification of the Spirit, unto obedience" (1 Pet. 1:2). Election, foreknowledge, sanctification, obedience. And he goes on, "Because it is written, Be ye holy; for I am holy" (1 Pet. 1:16).

To find individual election to salvation in Ephesians 1, you must bring it with you. No new believer reading that chapter for the first time would conclude that he had no choice in his salvation. He would have to be taught that first.

Foreknowledge Is Not Force

Calvinists often argue that if God knows everything in advance, then he must have determined everything in advance. But knowing something will happen is not the same as causing it. A father may know that his child is about to make a foolish choice without making him do it. God's foreknowledge is perfect, but the Bible never says that his foreknowledge is the same thing as his decree.

Consider hell. The Lord said it was "prepared for the devil and his angels" (Matt. 25:41). If God had decreed from eternity that most of mankind would end up there, it would have been prepared for them too. The Bible says it was not.

Romans 9 and the Nations

The Calvinist's favorite chapter is Romans 9, and his starting point is usually verse 13: "As it is written, Jacob have I loved, but Esau have I hated." Before the twins were born, God loved one

and hated the other. That, they say, is how God works in individual salvation today.

But Romans 9 through 11 is about Israel as a nation. Chapter 9 is Israel's past, chapter 10 its present, and chapter 11 its future. And Paul tells us that verse 13 is a quotation: "as it is written." The source is Malachi 1:2–3, where God says to Israel, "I loved Jacob, And I hated Esau, and laid his mountains and his heritage waste for the dragons of the wilderness." The very next verse calls Edom "The people against whom the LORD hath indignation for ever" (Mal. 1:4). Genesis tells us plainly, "Esau is Edom" (Gen. 36:8), and when the twins were still in the womb God said, "Two nations are in thy womb, and two manner of people shall be separated from thy bowels… and the elder shall serve the younger" (Gen. 25:23). Romans 9:12 quotes that very prophecy. The subject is two nations, Israel and Edom, and which one God would use to bring the Messiah into the world.

The surrounding verses are plural throughout. "Who are Israelites… Whose are the fathers" (Rom. 9:4–5). "For they are not all Israel, which are of Israel: Neither, because they are the seed of Abraham, are they all children" (Rom. 9:6–7). "They which are the children of the flesh, these are not the children of God: but the children of the promise are counted for the seed" (Rom. 9:8). Paul is talking about peoples and lines of descent, not about individual souls being assigned to heaven or hell.

Jacob was not elected to eternal salvation through the blood of Christ, which had not yet been shed, but to be the father of the chosen nation. The purpose of God according to election in Romans 9:11 concerns the covenant line.

Even Israel's election was not unconditional in the Calvinist sense. It rested on God's oath to Abraham, and God tells us why he swore it: "because thou hast done this thing, and hast not withheld thy son… because thou hast obeyed my voice" (Gen. 22:16, 18). He repeated it to Isaac: "Because that Abraham obeyed my voice, and kept my charge" (Gen. 26:5). God loved Israel "because he would keep the oath which he had sworn

unto your fathers" (Deut. 7:8). There was a reason, and it traced back to Abraham's faith.

Hated Means Loved Less

The word *hated* also has to be read the way the Bible uses it. When Jacob married two sisters, "he loved also Rachel more than Leah," and then, "when the LORD saw that Leah was hated" (Gen. 29:30–31). Jacob did not despise Leah; he loved her less. Compare two parallel sayings of the Lord Jesus. Luke records, "If any man come to me, and hate not his father, and mother… he cannot be my disciple" (Luke 14:26). Matthew records the same teaching this way: "He that loveth father or mother more than me is not worthy of me" (Matt. 10:37). The Bible defines its own word. To hate, in this comparison, is to love less.

Esau and Pharaoh Chose First

Even on the personal level, Esau was not rejected for no reason. He came in from the field hungry and sold his birthright for a bowl of pottage. "Thus Esau despised his birthright" (Gen. 25:34). Hebrews calls him a "profane person… who for one morsel of meat sold his birthright" (Heb. 12:16). Jacob was a deceiver, but he valued God's promise. Esau despised it.

Paul's next example is Pharaoh: "For this same purpose have I raised thee up, that I might shew my power in thee" (Rom. 9:17). Calvinists read this as God hardening a man who never had a genuine opportunity to respond. The account in Exodus shows otherwise. When Moses first spoke to him, Pharaoh answered, "Who is the LORD, that I should obey his voice to let Israel go? I know not the LORD, neither will I let Israel go" (Exod. 5:2). Then, after the plagues began, "he hardened his heart" (Exod. 8:15), and again, "Pharaoh hardened his heart at this time also" (Exod. 8:32). Only after that do we read, "And the LORD hardened the heart of Pharaoh" (Exod. 9:12). God had foretold he would do it, but Pharaoh had already made his choice. The principle of Romans 9 is not that God rejects people who wanted

him. It is that God confirms the choice of those who reject him. "Draw nigh to God, and he will draw nigh to you" (James 4:8).

The Potter and the Clay

Calvinists move from Pharaoh to the most quoted lines in the chapter:

Romans 9:19–21

"Thou wilt say then unto me, Why doth he yet find fault? For who hath resisted his will? Nay but, O man, who art thou that repliest against God? Shall the thing formed say to him that formed it, Why hast thou made me thus? Hath not the potter power over the clay, of the same lump to make one vessel unto honour, and another unto dishonour?"

Here, they say, is proof that God makes some people for heaven and others for hell, and no one may question it.

But Paul did not invent the image of the potter. It comes from Jeremiah, and there God explained exactly what it means. Jeremiah went down to the potter's house and watched him work: "And the vessel that he made of clay was marred in the hand of the potter: so he made it again another vessel, as seemed good to the potter to make it" (Jer. 18:4). Then the word of the Lord came: "O house of Israel, cannot I do with you as this potter? saith the LORD. Behold, as the clay is in the potter's hand, so are ye in mine hand, O house of Israel" (Jer. 18:6).

God himself explains how the potter decides:

Jeremiah 18:7–10

"At what instant I shall speak concerning a nation, and concerning a kingdom, to pluck up, and to pull down, and to destroy it; If that nation, against whom I have pronounced, turn from their evil, I will repent of the evil that I thought to do unto them. And at what instant I shall speak concerning a nation, and concerning a kingdom, to build and to plant it; If it do evil in my sight, that it obey not my voice, then I will repent of the good, wherewith I said I would benefit them."

The potter's power is real, and no one may talk back to him. But the potter responds to what the clay does. If a nation turns from evil, he remakes it for good. If it turns to evil, he remakes it for judgment. The very passage Paul draws from teaches that God's shaping takes account of repentance. It is about nations, just as Romans 9 is, and it is conditional.

Paul's next words are equally important: "What if God, willing to shew his wrath, and to make his power known, endured with much longsuffering the vessels of wrath fitted to destruction: And that he might make known the riches of his glory on the vessels of mercy, which he had afore prepared unto glory" (Rom. 9:22–23). God "endured with much longsuffering" the vessels of wrath. Why would God need patience with vessels that had no choice? The same word describes his patience in 2 Peter 3:9, where he "is longsuffering to us-ward, not willing that any should perish." The difference in wording is important: the vessels of mercy are those "which *he* had afore prepared unto glory," but the vessels of wrath are simply "fitted to destruction." Paul does not say God fitted them, and the Greek participle (*katērtismena*) can just as well be read "fitted themselves." Their own rebellion made them ready for destruction, while God endured them with patience.

Paul uses the vessel picture again in 2 Timothy, and there it is plainly something a man can change:

2 Timothy 2:20–21

"But in a great house there are not only vessels of gold and of silver, but also of wood and of earth; and some to honour, and some to dishonour. If a man therefore purge himself from these, he shall be a vessel unto honour, sanctified, and meet for the master's use."

"If a man therefore purge himself." What kind of vessel a man becomes depends in part on him.

Why Israel Failed

Paul himself tells us at the end of Romans 9 why Israel stumbled. It was not because God had arbitrarily passed them by.

Romans 9:30–32

"What shall we say then? That the Gentiles, which followed not after righteousness, have attained to righteousness, even the righteousness which is of faith. But Israel, which followed after the law of righteousness, hath not attained to the law of righteousness. Wherefore? Because they sought it not by faith, but as it were by the works of the law. For they stumbled at that stumblingstone."

"Wherefore? Because they sought it not by faith." That is the explanation Paul gives for the whole chapter. The Gentiles attained righteousness by faith. Israel missed it because they would not seek it by faith. If Romans 9 were teaching that God decides who will believe, this would have been the place to say so. Instead Paul gives a reason rooted in Israel's own choice. The chapter that Calvinists open first ends by refuting them.

As Many as Were Ordained

Another verse often used for unconditional election is Acts 13:48: "And when the Gentiles heard this, they were glad, and glorified the word of the Lord: and as many as were ordained to eternal life believed." This verse is often read as teaching that God ordained who would believe.

The context two verses earlier is important. Paul and Barnabas said to the Jews of Antioch, "It was necessary that the word of God should first have been spoken to you: but seeing ye put it from you, and judge yourselves unworthy of everlasting life, lo, we turn to the Gentiles" (Acts 13:46). The Jews who rejected the gospel judged *themselves* unworthy. Luke puts the responsibility for their unbelief squarely on them. The Greek word translated "ordained" (*tetagmenoi*) means set in order, appointed, or disposed, and the verse does not say when or on what basis they

were so set. Luke has just shown that the difference between the two groups was how they responded to the word: one put it from them, the other gladly received it. To read Acts 13:48 as eternal, unconditional election, one must ignore Acts 13:46.

God's Pleasure and God's Pleading

The Bible tells us God created all things for his pleasure: "Thou art worthy, O Lord, to receive glory and honour and power: for thou hast created all things, and for thy pleasure they are and were created" (Rev. 4:11). If God created most of mankind for damnation, then their damnation would be his pleasure. But God says the opposite: "Say unto them, As I live, saith the Lord GOD, I have no pleasure in the death of the wicked; but that the wicked turn from his way and live: turn ye, turn ye from your evil ways; for why will ye die, O house of Israel?" (Ezek. 33:11). "Have I any pleasure at all that the wicked should die? saith the Lord GOD: and not that he should return from his ways, and live?" (Ezek. 18:23).

That is God pleading. Turn ye, turn ye. Why will ye die? God does not plead with people to do what he has already determined they cannot do. Peter says it plainly: "The Lord is not slack concerning his promise, as some men count slackness; but is longsuffering to us-ward, not willing that any should perish, but that all should come to repentance" (2 Pet. 3:9). In the English of the King James Bible, *willing* meant "pleased; desirous."[60] God does not desire that any perish. He is not the one sending men to hell by his secret decree. And Paul wrote that God "will have all men to be saved, and to come unto the knowledge of the truth" (1 Tim. 2:4).

Calvin saw the problem this verse creates for his system and addressed it directly. On 2 Peter 3:9 he wrote:

[60]Noah Webster, *An American Dictionary of the English Language* (New York: S. Converse, 1828), s.v. "willing."

> "But it may be asked, If God wishes none to perish, why is it that so many do perish? To this my answer is, that no mention is here made of the hidden purpose of God, according to which the reprobate are doomed to their own ruin, but only of his will as made known to us in the gospel."[61]

In other words, God has two wills: a revealed will in the gospel that desires all to be saved, and a hidden will by which most were doomed before they were born. The Bible never teaches that. It says, "The secret things belong unto the LORD our God: but those things which are revealed belong unto us and to our children for ever" (Deut. 29:29). God does not reveal one thing and secretly will the opposite. When he says he is not willing that any should perish, he means it.

People can even refuse what God wills for them. "But the Pharisees and lawyers rejected the counsel of God against themselves, being not baptized of him" (Luke 7:30). God is sovereign. We believe that with all our hearts. But his sovereignty is great enough to give men a real choice and still accomplish everything he has purposed.

If God Chose Arbitrarily

A further consideration deserves mention. If God truly chose individuals for salvation arbitrarily, we would expect him to have chosen the people he loved most. Israel is "the apple of his eye" (Zech. 2:8). Yet in this age, most of Israel has rejected Christ, and the gospel has gone out mainly to the Gentiles. That makes perfect sense if salvation is received by faith and can be refused. It makes very little sense if God simply picked the saved without any conditions at all.

Think of what unconditional election means in a family. A Calvinist father, if he is consistent, must believe that some of his

[61]John Calvin, *Commentaries on the Catholic Epistles*, trans. John Owen (Edinburgh: Calvin Translation Society, 1855), comment on 2 Pet. 3:9.

own children may have been passed over before they were born, for no reason, and that nothing he can do or pray will change it. Is it any wonder that some raised under this teaching walk away from God altogether? That is not the God of the Bible. The God of the Bible so loved the world.

LIMITED ATONEMENT

The third point follows from the first two. If God chose only some for salvation, then Christ died only for them. The Canons of Dort say that "it was the will of God, that Christ by the blood of the cross… should effectually redeem out of every people, tribe, nation, and language, all those, and those only, who were from eternity chosen to salvation, and given to him by the Father."[62] Calvinists today often prefer the term *definite atonement* or *particular redemption*, but the teaching is the same: Christ did not die for everyone.

Stated plainly, the doctrine teaches that Jesus did not die for everyone. That statement contradicts what most Christians have always understood the gospel to say, and for good reason.

The Argument from Double Payment

The best-known argument for limited atonement comes from the Puritan John Owen, who put it as a choice among three options.[63] Either Christ died for all the sins of all men, or for all the sins of some men, or for some sins of all men. If he died for all the sins of all men, then he died for their unbelief, and unbelief can no longer condemn anyone, so all would be saved. Since not all are saved, he must have died for all the sins of some men, namely the elect.

In Owen's own words, "God imposed his wrath due unto, and Christ underwent the pains of hell for, either all the sins of all men, or all the sins of some men, or some sins for all men." If Christ died for all the sins of all men, Owen asked, "why then are not all freed from the punishment of all their sins? You will say, because of their unbelief… but this unbelief, is it a sin or

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[62]Canons of Dort, Second Head of Doctrine, art. 8, in Schaff, *Creeds of Christendom*, vol. 3.

[63]John Owen, *The Death of Death in the Death of Christ* (1647; repr., Philadelphia: Wm. Green and George W. M'Laughlin, 1827), bk. 1, chap. 3, 40–41.

not?"[64] The argument is ingenious, but it treats unbelief into just one more sin on the list, like lying or stealing, as though a man could be forgiven for refusing forgiveness. The Bible does not treat unbelief that way. Unbelief is the refusal of the payment itself. "He that believeth on him is not condemned: but he that believeth not is condemned already, because he hath not believed in the name of the only begotten Son of God" (John 3:18).

A related argument is sometimes called double jeopardy. If Christ paid for a man's sins, God cannot justly punish that man for them again. So if anyone goes to hell, Christ must not have paid for his sins, or else they would be paid for twice.

Both arguments are philosophy, not Scripture. Double jeopardy is a principle of human law. It is nowhere in the Bible as a limit on the atonement. And both arguments confuse two things the Bible keeps distinct: what Christ provided and what a sinner receives. Christ's death paid for the sins of the whole world. But that payment is applied only to those who receive it by faith. A gift can be fully paid for and still refused.

The Passover and the Serpent

God gave Israel two pictures of this. At the Passover, the lamb was slain for every household, and God said, "when I see the blood, I will pass over you" (Exod. 12:13). The blood was provided, but it had to be applied to the doorposts. Those who applied it were spared. Those who did not were not. The provision was for all; the application was by faith.

In the wilderness, when the people were bitten by fiery serpents, God told Moses to set a brass serpent on a pole, "and it shall come to pass, that every one that is bitten, when he looketh upon it, shall live" (Num. 21:8). The serpent was lifted up for every bitten Israelite, not for a select few. Those who looked lived. The Lord Jesus applied this very picture to his cross: "And as Moses

[64]Owen, *The Death of Death*, bk. 1, chap. 3.

lifted up the serpent in the wilderness, even so must the Son of man be lifted up: That whosoever believeth in him should not perish, but have eternal life" (John 3:14–15).

What the Bible Says

The plainest way to answer limited atonement is to read what the Bible says about whom Christ died for.

"For there is one God, and one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus; Who gave himself a ransom for all" (1 Tim. 2:5–6). "But we see Jesus, who was made a little lower than the angels for the suffering of death, crowned with glory and honour; that he by the grace of God should taste death for every man" (Heb. 2:9). "All we like sheep have gone astray; we have turned every one to his own way; and the LORD hath laid on him the iniquity of us all" (Isa. 53:6). "Because we thus judge, that if one died for all, then were all dead: And that he died for all" (2 Cor. 5:14–15). "God was in Christ, reconciling the world unto himself, not imputing their trespasses unto them" (2 Cor. 5:19). "Therefore as by the offence of one judgment came upon all men to condemnation; even so by the righteousness of one the free gift came upon all men unto justification of life" (Rom. 5:18).

All means all, and world means world. A Calvinist must say in each place that "all" means "all the elect" and "world" means "the world of the elect." But that is not what the verses say, and it is not how anyone would read them without a system to protect.

Calvin himself had to explain away these verses. On 1 Timothy 2:4 he wrote that "the present discourse relates to classes of men, and not to individual persons."[65] In Calvin's reading, "all men" means all kinds of men. Not every Calvinist accepted that interpretation. Charles Spurgeon, himself a Calvinist, preached

[65]John Calvin, *Commentaries on the Epistles to Timothy, Titus, and Philemon*, trans. William Pringle (Edinburgh: Calvin Translation Society, 1856), comment on 1 Tim. 2:4.

on the same text: "What then? Shall we try to put another meaning into the text than that which it fairly bears? I trow not." He described how older Calvinists read it, "'All men,' say they, 'that is, some men': as if the Holy Ghost could not have said 'some men' if he had meant some men," and he concluded, "The Holy Ghost by the apostle has written 'all men,' and unquestionably he means all men."[66] We agree with Spurgeon on that sentence. When God says all, he means all.

Peter even says Christ bought false teachers who will be lost: "But there were false prophets also among the people, even as there shall be false teachers among you, who privily shall bring in damnable heresies, even denying the Lord that bought them, and bring upon themselves swift destruction" (2 Pet. 2:1). These are not elect believers. They bring in damnable heresies and swift destruction on themselves. Yet the Lord bought them. He paid for people who will never be saved.

The Whole World in First John

The clearest verse of all is 1 John 2:2: "And he is the propitiation for our sins: and not for ours only, but also for the sins of the whole world." John says Christ is the payment for our sins, the sins of believers, and not for ours only. If "the whole world" meant the elect, the verse would say, "not for the elect only, but also for the elect," which is nonsense.

We do not have to guess what John means by *world*, because he uses the word again and again in the same letter. "Therefore the world knoweth us not, because it knew him not" (1 John 3:1). "Marvel not, my brethren, if the world hate you" (1 John 3:13). The spirit of antichrist "even now already is it in the world" (1 John 4:3). "They are of the world: therefore speak they of the

[66]Charles H. Spurgeon, "Salvation by Knowing the Truth," sermon no. 1516, Metropolitan Tabernacle, in *Spurgeon's Sermons*, vol. 26 (1880) (Grand Rapids, MI: Christian Classics Ethereal Library), https://ccel.org/ccel/spurgeon/sermons26. In fairness to Spurgeon, he still held that God does not will the salvation of all "with the force of a decree."

world, and the world heareth them" (1 John 4:5). "And we know that we are of God, and the whole world lieth in wickedness" (1 John 5:19). In every one of those verses, the world is set against believers. The world does not know us, hates us, hears the false teachers, and lies in wickedness. It cannot possibly mean the elect. And that world, "the whole world," is the world for whose sins Christ is the propitiation.

Calvin, commenting on this very verse, admitted the older view that Christ "suffered sufficiently for the whole world, but efficiently only for the elect," and then rejected even that for this passage: "under the word all or whole, he does not include the reprobate, but designates those who should believe."[67] This is the interpretive move described above. John wrote "the whole world," and the system requires it to mean something smaller. But John's own letter tells us what he means by the world, and it is not the elect.

The Sheep and the Many

Calvinists point to verses that sound more limited. "I lay down my life for the sheep" (John 10:15). "Feed the church of God, which he hath purchased with his own blood" (Acts 20:28). "He bare the sin of many" (Isa. 53:12). "I pray not for the world, but for them which thou hast given me" (John 17:9).

All of those verses are true. Christ did die for his sheep, and for the church, and for many. But saying that Christ died for the sheep does not say that he died *only* for the sheep. Many is included in all; it does not contradict it. When the Bible says in one place that Christ died for all and for the whole world, and in another place that he died for the church, the second statement is part of the first. It cannot cancel it. And John 17 is about the Lord's prayer for his disciples on the night before the cross, not about the extent of the atonement.

[67]Calvin, *Commentaries on the Catholic Epistles*, comment on 1 John 2:2.

This is a basic rule of Bible study: never use an unclear passage to overturn a clear one. The clear statements that Christ died for all, for the world, and for whosoever believes should serve as anchors, and the harder passages should be read in their light. The Calvinist method reverses this order. He starts with a few verses that can be read in a limited way and uses them to empty the clear verses of their meaning.

IRRESISTIBLE GRACE

The fourth point follows from the first three. If God chose only certain people, and Christ died only for them, then when God calls them, they cannot refuse. The Canons of Dort describe regeneration as a work that God performs in us "without our aid," and say that it is not accomplished in such a way that "after God has performed his part, it still remains in the power of man to be regenerated or not, to be converted or to continue unconverted." Rather, "all in whose hearts God works in this marvelous manner are certainly, infallibly, and effectually regenerated, and do actually believe."[68]

Calvinists will tell you that no one is saved against his will. They mean that God changes the will so that the person then wants to believe. But the point is the same. The sinner has no say. God makes him willing, and he cannot resist.

The General Call and the Effectual Call

Calvinists cannot deny that people in the Bible reject God's offers. They therefore divide God's call into two kinds. The general call is the outward preaching of the gospel, which anyone can resist. The effectual call is the inward work of the Spirit in the elect, which no one can resist. When someone in Scripture rejects God, they say, he resisted only the general call.

That distinction is not found in the Bible. It was developed to protect the system, and a single verse is enough to overturn it.

Ye Do Always Resist the Holy Ghost

Stephen, full of the Holy Ghost, ended his sermon to the council in Jerusalem with these words: "Ye stiffnecked and uncircumcised in heart and ears, ye do always resist the Holy Ghost: as your fathers did, so do ye" (Acts 7:51).

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[68]Canons of Dort, Third and Fourth Heads of Doctrine, art. 12, in Schaff, *Creeds of Christendom*, vol. 3.

Each part of that sentence is significant. They were uncircumcised "in heart," so this is an inward matter, not merely outward hearing. They resisted "the Holy Ghost," not just a preacher's words. They did it "always," as their fathers had done before them, and Stephen had just traced that history from Joseph through Moses to the prophets. If the Holy Ghost can be resisted, grace is not irresistible.

This is not a new observation. When the followers of Arminius set out their five articles in 1610, they denied that grace is irresistible "inasmuch as it is written concerning many, that they have resisted the Holy Ghost. Acts vii., and elsewhere in many places."[69] The Calvinists at Dort answered with the articles quoted above, but they could not make Acts 7:51 say anything other than what it says.

And Ye Would Not

The Bible is full of the same truth. "Because I have called, and ye refused; I have stretched out my hand, and no man regarded" (Prov. 1:24). The Lord Jesus wept over Jerusalem: "O Jerusalem, Jerusalem, thou that killest the prophets, and stonest them which are sent unto thee, how often would I have gathered thy children together, even as a hen gathereth her chickens under her wings, and ye would not!" (Matt. 23:37). He would; they would not. His will was resisted. "And ye will not come to me, that ye might have life" (John 5:40).

Watch what happens when the gospel is preached in Acts. At Pentecost, the hearers "were pricked in their heart," asked what to do, and about three thousand "gladly received his word" (Acts 2:37, 41). But when the apostles preached to the council, "they were cut to the heart, and took counsel to slay them" (Acts 5:33), and when Stephen finished, "they were cut to the heart, and they gnashed on him with their teeth" (Acts 7:54). The same message, the same conviction, two responses. Some received it

[69]The Five Arminian Articles (1610), art. 4, in Schaff, *Creeds of Christendom*, vol. 3.

and some hardened their hearts. That is what happens every time the gospel is preached.

They Would Not Come

The Lord Jesus told a parable of a king who made a marriage feast for his son. "And sent forth his servants to call them that were bidden to the wedding: and they would not come" (Matt. 22:3). In Luke's version, the servant announced, "Come; for all things are now ready. And they all with one consent began to make excuse" (Luke 14:17–18). The invitation was real, the feast was ready, and the invited guests refused. The king was angry with them, not because they could not come, but because they would not.

At the end of Luke's parable the master says, "Go out into the highways and hedges, and compel them to come in, that my house may be filled" (Luke 14:23). The servants had only words to compel with. They were to urge and persuade. But Augustine used this very verse to justify the use of state force against the Donatists. "The Church, in trying to compel the Donatists, is following the example of her Lord," he wrote, citing "compel them to come in" as the Lord's own instruction.[70] The connection between a theology of irresistible grace and a church willing to use force is not accidental. If God overpowers the will, a church may conclude that it may do the same. The Lord's servants in the parable pleaded. They did not coerce.

The New Testament keeps warning people not to refuse God. "Wherefore (as the Holy Ghost saith, To day if ye will hear his voice, Harden not your hearts, as in the provocation" (Heb. 3:7–8). "See that ye refuse not him that speaketh" (Heb. 12:25). Paul even pleaded with believers: "We then, as workers together with him, beseech you also that ye receive not the grace of God in vain" (2 Cor. 6:1). You cannot warn someone not to refuse what

[70]Augustine, *The Correction of the Donatists* 6.23–24, trans. J. R. King, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, 1st ser., vol. 4, ed. Philip Schaff (New York: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1890).

cannot be refused, and you cannot receive in vain a grace that always accomplishes its purpose.

God Gives Real Choices

From the beginning, God has dealt with his creatures as beings who can choose. He put the tree of the knowledge of good and evil in the garden (Gen. 2:9) and let Eve and Adam choose (Gen. 3:6). Lucifer was created perfect, "till iniquity was found in thee" (Ezek. 28:15), and he chose to say, "I will be like the most High" (Isa. 14:14). When Agabus warned Paul that he would be bound at Jerusalem, his friends begged him not to go, and he chose to go anyway, and "when he would not be persuaded, we ceased, saying, The will of the Lord be done" (Acts 21:14).

There are things God has determined will happen, and they will happen exactly as he said. The Bible calls these his counsel and his purpose. But much of what happens in the world God permits rather than causes, and he works around the choices of men to bring about what he has promised. That is not a weakness in God. It is part of his greatness. He is powerful enough to give men a real choice and still accomplish all his will.

Forced Love Is Not Love

There is one more thing to say about irresistible grace, and it may be the most important. Love that is forced is not love. No husband wants a wife who is with him because she has no choice. He wants her to love him freely. God made us in his image with the capacity to choose, and he wants children who come to him because they love him, not because he overpowered their wills. Everywhere in human life, love imposed on someone against their will is recognized as something wrong. It does not become right when it is applied to God. The God of the Bible stands at the door and knocks (Rev. 3:20). He does not break it down.

GOD'S WORK TOWARD EVERY SINNER

The previous chapters answered the five points one at a time. This chapter gathers a body of Scripture that bears on all of them together. The Bible describes God as actively working toward every sinner: enlightening, convicting, drawing, restraining, and pleading. Calvinism teaches that God's saving work is directed only toward the elect, and that the non-elect receive at most an outward call they are unable to answer. The passages that follow describe something far more personal and far more universal.

The Light That Lighteth Every Man

John introduces Christ as "the true Light, which lighteth every man that cometh into the world" (John 1:9). The light is not given only to believers or to the elect. It is given to "every man." The same chapter explains why that light is given: John the Baptist came "to bear witness of the Light, that all men through him might believe" (John 1:7). The purpose of the witness was that all men might believe, and the light that accompanies it reaches every man. Whatever else this means, it cannot mean that most men are left in total darkness without any divine influence toward faith.

The Spirit Convicts the World

On the night before the crucifixion, the Lord described the work of the Holy Spirit after his departure: "And when he is come, he will reprove the world of sin, and of righteousness, and of judgment: Of sin, because they believe not on me" (John 16:8–9). The Spirit's convicting work is directed toward "the world," and the sin of which he convicts them is unbelief: "because they believe not on me." A person cannot be justly convicted of failing to do what he was never able to do. The Spirit convicts the world of unbelief because unbelief is a real refusal of a real offer.

Grace Has Appeared to All Men

Paul wrote to Titus, "For the grace of God that bringeth salvation hath appeared to all men" (Titus 2:11). The grace in view is saving grace, "the grace of God that bringeth salvation," and it has appeared "to all men." Calvinists usually read this as "all kinds of men," as Calvin did with 1 Timothy 2:4. But the ordinary meaning of the words is the natural one, and it agrees with everything else the Bible says about God's desire for the salvation of the world.

The Goodness of God Leadeth to Repentance

In Romans 2 Paul addresses the man who judges others while doing the same things. "Or despisest thou the riches of his goodness and forbearance and longsuffering; not knowing that the goodness of God leadeth thee to repentance? But after thy hardness and impenitent heart treasurest up unto thyself wrath against the day of wrath" (Rom. 2:4–5). God's goodness was leading this man to repentance. His hardness and impenitence were his own, and they stored up wrath "unto thyself." Paul does not say that God withheld the means of repentance. He says that God's goodness was leading the man toward it and that the man despised it.

That They Should Seek the Lord

Preaching to the philosophers of Athens, Paul described God's purpose in ordering the nations:

Acts 17:26–27

"And hath made of one blood all nations of men for to dwell on all the face of the earth, and hath determined the times before appointed, and the bounds of their habitation; That they should seek the Lord, if haply they might feel after him, and find him, though he be not far from every one of us."

God determined the times and places of the nations with a purpose: "that they should seek the Lord." He is "not far from every one of us." This was spoken to pagan idolaters, not to

believers. God's providence over all mankind is directed toward their seeking and finding him.

Paul makes the same point from the other direction in Romans 1. The knowledge of God is available to all men through creation, "so that they are without excuse: Because that, when they knew God, they glorified him not as God" (Rom. 1:20–21). Men are without excuse because they knew and refused. If they had been unable to respond to any knowledge of God, the excuse would be complete.

They Would Have Repented

One of the most striking statements in the Gospels concerns cities that never repented. The Lord said, "Woe unto thee, Chorazin! woe unto thee, Bethsaida! for if the mighty works, which were done in you, had been done in Tyre and Sidon, they would have repented long ago in sackcloth and ashes" (Matt. 11:21). Of Sodom he added, "if the mighty works, which have been done in thee, had been done in Sodom, it would have remained until this day" (Matt. 11:23).

The Lord says that the people of Tyre, Sidon, and Sodom would have repented if they had seen what Chorazin and Bethsaida saw. On the Calvinist view, the repentance of Tyre and Sidon would have required regenerating grace, and the absence of miracles would have made no difference either way. But the Lord ties their hypothetical repentance to the evidence they would have seen, not to a secret decree. He also holds Chorazin and Bethsaida more accountable because they saw more. Greater light brings greater responsibility only if men are able to respond to light.

What More Could Have Been Done?

Isaiah records God's lament over Israel under the figure of a vineyard. God had fenced it, cleared it, planted it with the choicest vine, and built a tower and a winepress in it. Then he asked, "What could have been done more to my vineyard, that I have not done in it? wherefore, when I looked that it should

bring forth grapes, brought it forth wild grapes?" (Isa. 5:4). The question has force only if God had truly done everything necessary for the vineyard to bear fruit. If Israel's fruitlessness were the result of God's withholding the one thing that could have made it fruitful, the answer to God's question would be obvious, and the lament would make no sense.

Ezekiel records a command that assumes the same responsibility: "Cast away from you all your transgressions, whereby ye have transgressed; and make you a new heart and a new spirit: for why will ye die, O house of Israel?" (Ezek. 18:31). God is the one who gives a new heart (Ezek. 36:26), and no one can regenerate himself. Yet God commands Israel to turn and "make you a new heart," because turning to God is the human side of what God does in the heart of the one who turns.

Receiving Grace in Vain

The New Testament also warns that God's grace can be received and yet fail to accomplish its purpose in a person. Paul pleaded with the Corinthians, "We then, as workers together with him, beseech you also that ye receive not the grace of God in vain" (2 Cor. 6:1). Hebrews warns, "Looking diligently lest any man fail of the grace of God; lest any root of bitterness springing up trouble you" (Heb. 12:15). If grace were irresistible, it could never be received in vain, and no one could "fail of the grace of God." The warnings assume that grace can be refused.

The Pattern of Scripture

Taken together, these passages describe a God who lights every man, convicts the world, displays his saving grace to all men, leads sinners toward repentance by his goodness, arranges the history of nations so that men might seek him, and grieves when his work is refused. Calvinism must reinterpret each of these statements to preserve its system: "every man" becomes the elect, "the world" becomes the elect, "all men" becomes all kinds of men, and God's lament becomes a statement about a vineyard he never intended to make fruitful. The simpler and more

faithful course is to believe what these passages say. God's work toward sinners is real, it is universal, and it can be resisted. Those who are lost are lost because, in the Lord's words, "ye would not" (Matt. 23:37).

PERSEVERANCE OF THE SAINTS

The last point is often mistaken for something Bible believers hold, because it sounds like eternal security. The Westminster Confession states it this way: "They whom God hath accepted in his Beloved, effectually called and sanctified by his Spirit, can neither totally nor finally fall away from the state of grace; but shall certainly persevere therein to the end, and be eternally saved."[71]

At first glance that looks like "once saved, always saved." But in practice it works very differently. In Calvinism the evidence that you were ever one of the elect is that you persevere in faith and holiness to the end. If a professing Christian falls into sin and does not come back, the conclusion is that he was never elect in the first place. The Canons of Dort say that assurance springs from God's promises, from the witness of the Spirit, "and, lastly, from a serious and holy desire to preserve a good conscience, and to perform good works."[72] Your assurance depends in part on how you are living.

A Return to Rome's Pattern

That brings Calvinism around, by a different road, to something very close to Rome. Roman Catholicism says: do the sacraments, persevere in good works, and if you endure to the end you will be saved. Calvinism says: if you are saved, you will persevere in good works, and if you do not endure to the end, you were never saved. One looks forward and the other looks back, but in both cases you cannot be sure of your salvation until you see how your life turns out. After insisting that faith is too much of a work to contribute to salvation, the system ends by making works the proof of it.

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[71]Westminster Confession of Faith 17.1, in Schaff, *Creeds of Christendom*, vol. 3.

[72]Canons of Dort, Fifth Head of Doctrine, art. 10, in Schaff, *Creeds of Christendom*, vol. 3.

The practical result is the opposite of eternal security. A believer whose walk goes up and down, and every believer's walk does, is left wondering on his bad days whether he was ever saved at all. We have known people who struggled for years under exactly this fear. Every human being who has ever lived, except the Lord Jesus himself, has had seasons of failure.

What About the Saints of the Bible?

If perseverance in holiness is the proof of salvation, then consider the people God himself calls righteous.

Lot pitched his tent toward Sodom, then lived in it, then sat in its gate. When the men of the city came to his door, he offered them his own daughters. He could not persuade his sons-in-law to leave. Afterward his daughters made him drunk and conceived by him (Gen. 19). By any standard of perseverance, Lot failed. Yet Peter calls him "just Lot" and "that righteous man" (2 Pet. 2:7–8).

David committed adultery with Bathsheba and had her husband murdered to cover it (2 Sam. 11). His family life was a wreck. Yet God called him "a man after mine own heart" (Acts 13:22), and his psalms are part of our Bible. What set David apart was not a spotless life but a heart that loved God and his word.

Solomon, the wisest man who ever lived, had seven hundred wives and three hundred concubines, and "his wives turned away his heart after other gods" (1 Kings 11:3–4). Yet he wrote Proverbs and Ecclesiastes.

Peter rebuked the Lord and was called Satan (Matt. 16:23). He cursed and swore that he did not know him (Matt. 26:74). Yet he was restored and became a pillar of the church.

Demas labored with Paul and is named alongside Luke in Paul's greetings (Col. 4:14; Philem. 24), but at the end Paul wrote, "Demas hath forsaken me, having loved this present world" (2 Tim. 4:10). John Mark turned back from the work so seriously that Paul refused to take him on the next journey (Acts 15:37–38).

Yet at the end of his life Paul wrote, "Take Mark, and bring him with thee: for he is profitable to me for the ministry" (2 Tim. 4:11), and Mark wrote one of the four Gospels. If Mark was not saved, then a book of the Bible was written by a lost man.

The Corinthian believers were divided and carnal (1 Cor. 3:1–3). One of them was living with his father's wife (1 Cor. 5:1), and they were taking one another to court before unbelievers (1 Cor. 6:6). Yet Paul called them brethren and "sanctified in Christ Jesus" (1 Cor. 1:2).

Paul listed the works of the flesh: "Adultery, fornication, uncleanness, lasciviousness, Idolatry, witchcraft, hatred, variance, emulations, wrath, strife, seditions, heresies, Envyings, murders, drunkenness, revellings, and such like" (Gal. 5:19–21). It would not be hard to find a saved person in the Bible guilty of nearly every one. That does not mean saved people should live that way. It means the Bible does not teach that the saved always persevere in holiness. God recorded the failures of his people so that we would know that salvation has never depended on our performance. There is only one who never failed, and he is the reason any of us are saved.

Saved, Yet So as by Fire

Paul describes a believer whose whole life's work is burned up at the judgment seat of Christ, and yet who is saved. "For other foundation can no man lay than that is laid, which is Jesus Christ… If any man's work shall be burned, he shall suffer loss: but he himself shall be saved; yet so as by fire" (1 Cor. 3:11, 15). Here is a man built on the right foundation, Christ, whose works amount to nothing that survives God's inspection. By the Calvinist test of perseverance, he should be counted as never having been saved. Paul says he is saved. He will lose his reward, but not his salvation.

The same letter deals with the man living in open immorality. Paul told the church to put him out, "To deliver such an one unto Satan for the destruction of the flesh, that the spirit may be

saved in the day of the Lord Jesus" (1 Cor. 5:5). Even under discipline, Paul expected the man's spirit to be saved. That is not the language of someone who believed that failure to persevere proves a person was never saved.

Our security does not rest on our faithfulness. It rests on his. "If we believe not, yet he abideth faithful: he cannot deny himself" (2 Tim. 2:13). "For he hath said, I will never leave thee, nor forsake thee" (Heb. 13:5).

The Thief and the Soils

On the other end, consider the thief on the cross. He had no time to persevere in anything. He believed and died the same day, and the Lord said, "To day shalt thou be with me in paradise" (Luke 23:43).

The parable of the sower speaks directly to this. Some seed fell by the wayside, and the devil took the word away "lest they should believe and be saved" (Luke 8:12). Some fell on the rock: they "for a while believe, and in time of temptation fall away" (Luke 8:13). Some fell among thorns and "bring no fruit to perfection" (Luke 8:14). Only the good ground brought forth fruit with patience (Luke 8:15). Many take the rocky and thorny ground to describe people who truly received the word but bore little or no lasting fruit. Whatever one concludes about each soil, the parable plainly does not teach that everyone who receives the word goes on to bear fruit to the end.

The Test of Fruit

This does not mean that fruit is unimportant. Paul wrote, "For by grace are ye saved through faith; and that not of yourselves: it is the gift of God: Not of works, lest any man should boast. For we are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus unto good works" (Eph. 2:8–10). Every believer ought to bear fruit, and a changed life is one of the blessings of salvation. The Lord said false prophets would be known by their fruits (Matt. 7:15–16). But the Bible does not make a believer's fruit the test of whether he is saved. We cannot see into another person's heart. The most

we can judge is his confession. "That if thou shalt confess with thy mouth the Lord Jesus, and shalt believe in thine heart that God hath raised him from the dead, thou shalt be saved" (Rom. 10:9).

The believer's security rests on something far better than his own perseverance. It rests on the promise of God. "And I give unto them eternal life; and they shall never perish, neither shall any man pluck them out of my hand" (John 10:28). "And grieve not the holy Spirit of God, whereby ye are sealed unto the day of redemption" (Eph. 4:30). "These things have I written unto you that believe on the name of the Son of God; that ye may know that ye have eternal life" (1 John 5:13). That ye may know. Not that ye may hope, or wait and see. God wants his children to know.

ANSWERING THE HARD PASSAGES

We have looked at the main passages used for each point of Calvinism. A few more are quoted often enough that they deserve a direct answer. In every case the principle is the same: read the verse in its context, and let the clear verses interpret the harder ones.

"Salvation Is of the LORD"

Jonah prayed from inside the fish, "Salvation is of the LORD" (Jonah 2:9). Calvinists use this as a summary of their system. We say amen to the verse. Salvation is of the Lord. He planned it, provided it, purchased it, and applies it. The question is not whether salvation is of the Lord but whether the Lord offers it to all and allows it to be refused. The book of Jonah itself answers that question. God sent Jonah to Nineveh with a message of judgment, and "the people of Nineveh believed God" and turned from their evil way, "and God repented of the evil, that he had said that he would do unto them; and he did it not" (Jonah 3:5, 10). That is Jeremiah 18 in action. The salvation was of the Lord, and the Ninevites turned.

"Not of the Will of Man"

John 1:13 says believers "were born, not of blood, nor of the will of the flesh, nor of the will of man, but of God." Calvinists read this as proof that man's will has no part in salvation. But look at the verse before it: "But as many as received him, to them gave he power to become the sons of God, even to them that believe on his name" (John 1:12). Receiving and believing come first, and then God gives the power to become his sons. Verse 13 tells us the *source* of the new birth. It is not by blood (being born a Jew), not by the will of the flesh (human effort), and not by the will of man (another person deciding it for you). It is of God. Verse 12 tells us who receives that birth: those who receive him.

"It Is Given to Believe"

Paul wrote, "For unto you it is given in the behalf of Christ, not only to believe on him, but also to suffer for his sake" (Phil. 1:29). The verse does not make faith a gift given only to some, because suffering is described as given in exactly the same way. Paul is saying that believing on Christ and suffering for Christ are both privileges God has granted. He is not saying that God decides which people will believe any more than he decides which believers will choose to endure persecution faithfully. God gives the privilege of believing to all to whom the gospel comes, "For the grace of God that bringeth salvation hath appeared to all men" (Titus 2:11).

"Whose Heart the Lord Opened"

Luke tells us that Lydia, "which worshipped God, heard us: whose heart the Lord opened, that she attended unto the things which were spoken of Paul" (Acts 16:14). Calvinists say God opened her heart before she could believe. But Lydia was already a worshipper of God, a Gentile who had sought the God of Israel before she ever met Paul. She was seeking, and God led her to the full truth, just as he promised: "ye shall seek me, and find me, when ye shall search for me with all your heart" (Jer. 29:13). The Lord opens hearts through his word. That is what happened to the disciples on the Emmaus road too, when he opened the Scriptures to them. It does not mean he opens some hearts and seals the rest.

The Golden Chain

Romans 8:29–30 is called the golden chain of salvation: "For whom he did foreknow, he did also predestinate to be conformed to the image of his Son… Moreover whom he did predestinate, them he also called: and whom he called, them he also justified: and whom he justified, them he also glorified." Calvinists see an unbreakable sequence starting with an unconditional choice. But the chain begins with foreknowledge, and verse 28 has just described these people as "them that love

God, to them who are the called according to his purpose" (Rom. 8:28). The chain describes what God does for those who love him. And the goal of the predestination is "to be conformed to the image of his Son," not to be saved rather than lost. Paul is comforting believers that nothing can break God's purpose for them, which is exactly how the chapter ends: nothing "shall be able to separate us from the love of God, which is in Christ Jesus our Lord" (Rom. 8:39).

"Chosen to Salvation Through… Belief of the Truth"

Paul told the Thessalonians, "God hath from the beginning chosen you to salvation through sanctification of the Spirit and belief of the truth" (2 Thess. 2:13). Here God's choosing is tied directly to its means: the Spirit's work and "belief of the truth." God chose from the beginning that salvation would come to those who believe the truth. The next verse says how: "Whereunto he called you by our gospel" (2 Thess. 2:14). The call came through the preaching of the gospel, and they believed it.

"Ye Have Not Chosen Me"

The Lord told the disciples, "Ye have not chosen me, but I have chosen you, and ordained you, that ye should go and bring forth fruit" (John 15:16). He was speaking to the eleven about their calling as apostles, and he tells us what he chose them for: to go and bring forth fruit. He chose Judas too (John 6:70), and Judas was lost. Being chosen for a service is not the same as being chosen for salvation.

"Mercy on Whom I Will"

Finally, Romans 9:16: "So then it is not of him that willeth, nor of him that runneth, but of God that sheweth mercy." Paul is quoting God's words to Moses, "I will have mercy on whom I will have mercy" (Rom. 9:15). God has the absolute right to decide on whom he will have mercy. We agree completely. The question is, on whom has he decided to have mercy? Paul tells us two chapters later: "For God hath concluded them all in

unbelief, that he might have mercy upon all" (Rom. 11:32). God's sovereign decision is to have mercy on all who will receive it by faith. That is not man overruling God. That is God deciding, in his sovereignty, to save believers.

Believe the Works

One more passage shows the heart of the Lord Jesus toward those who did not believe. To the Jews who were about to stone him, he said, "But if I do, though ye believe not me, believe the works: that ye may know, and believe, that the Father is in me, and I in him" (John 10:38). He was still appealing to them, still giving them reasons to believe, still hoping they would. And when he came near Jerusalem, "he beheld the city, and wept over it, Saying, If thou hadst known, even thou, at least in this thy day, the things which belong unto thy peace! but now they are hid from thine eyes" (Luke 19:41–42). The Son of God does not weep over people he has passed by. He weeps over people who would not come.

EVANGELISM, PRAYER, AND ASSURANCE

Doctrine is never only a matter for the study. What a church believes about salvation shapes how it preaches, how it prays, and whether its people can rest in the promises of God. Calvinists and Bible-believing Christians who reject the system both preach the gospel, both pray for the lost, and both speak of assurance. But they do not mean the same things by them, and the difference is not small.

It should be said plainly that many Calvinists have been earnest preachers and soul winners. Spurgeon is only the most famous. Their zeal did not come from the five points. It came from the commands of the Bible, which tell every believer to preach the gospel to every creature. The question is which view of salvation fits those commands, and which one has to strain against them.

Preaching to Every Creature

The Lord Jesus sent his disciples out with a command that has no fence around it: "Go ye into all the world, and preach the gospel to every creature. He that believeth and is baptized shall be saved; but he that believeth not shall be damned" (Mark 16:15–16). Every creature is to hear the gospel, and every hearer is told that belief brings salvation and unbelief brings damnation. The command assumes that the offer is real for everyone who hears it.

Paul explained why preaching matters: "For whosoever shall call upon the name of the Lord shall be saved. How then shall they call on him in whom they have not believed? and how shall they believe in him of whom they have not heard? and how shall they hear without a preacher?" (Rom. 10:13–14). In Paul's chain, the preacher is not merely a formality that God uses to gather those whose destiny is already sealed. The sinner calls because he believes, he believes because he hears, and he hears because someone preaches. Take away the preacher, and the chain breaks.

Listen to how the apostle talked about his own ministry. "Knowing therefore the terror of the Lord, we persuade men" (2 Cor. 5:11). "Now then we are ambassadors for Christ, as though God did beseech you by us: we pray you in Christ's stead, be ye reconciled to God" (2 Cor. 5:20). "I am made all things to all men, that I might by all means save some" (1 Cor. 9:22). He reminded the Ephesian elders "that by the space of three years I ceased not to warn every one night and day with tears" (Acts 20:31). Persuading, beseeching, pleading with tears, becoming all things to all men so that by all means some might be saved: that is how a man speaks when he believes his hearers can respond, and that their response matters.

A consistent Calvinist can preach with the same words, but he cannot mean them in the same way. If God has fixed the number of the elect so that it "can not be either increased or diminished," as the Westminster Confession puts it,[73] then the preacher's tears do not change who is saved. The Calvinist answers that God ordains the means as well as the end, and that preaching is the means. But that answer only moves the problem back a step. The preacher is still addressing a crowd in which, by his own theology, Christ did not die for most of those listening, and he is still telling each of them that they must believe on a Savior who, for many of them, did not die for them.

Praying for All Men

Paul told Timothy how the church should pray:

1 Timothy 2:1–4

"I exhort therefore, that, first of all, supplications, prayers, intercessions, and giving of thanks, be made for all men; For kings, and for all that are in authority… For this is good and acceptable in the sight of God our Saviour; Who will have all men to be saved, and to come unto the knowledge of the truth."

[73]Westminster Confession of Faith 3.4, in Schaff, *Creeds of Christendom*, vol. 3.

The reason we pray for all men is that God will have all men to be saved. The prayer and the will of God are tied together.

Paul prayed that way for his own people: "Brethren, my heart's desire and prayer to God for Israel is, that they might be saved" (Rom. 10:1). He did not pray, "Save the elect among Israel, whoever they may be." He prayed for Israel. If the salvation of every person in Israel had been settled before the foundation of the world without regard to anything they would do, Paul's prayer could not change a single outcome. He prayed because he believed it mattered.

Every Christian parent who has prayed for a lost child knows the difference this makes. We pray because we believe God genuinely desires our child's salvation, that Christ genuinely died for that child, and that the child can genuinely turn to him. A Calvinist parent may pray just as earnestly, but his theology tells him that the answer was fixed before the child was born, and that if the child was not chosen, no prayer will change it.

Assurance

The deepest practical problem with Calvinism is assurance. The Bible wants believers to know they are saved: "These things have I written unto you that believe on the name of the Son of God; that ye may know that ye have eternal life" (1 John 5:13). The basis of that knowledge is the promise of God received by faith. "He that believeth on the Son hath everlasting life" (John 3:36). If I have believed on the Son, God says I have everlasting life, and I can rest on his word.

Calvinism puts a question behind that promise that no one can answer: was I elected? Election in the system is secret, decided before the world began, and not revealed to anyone by name. Calvin knew this was a danger. He told troubled believers not to search God's secret counsel but to look at Christ: "Christ, then, is the mirror in which we ought, and in which, without deception,

we may contemplate our election."[74] That is good advice as far as it goes. But in Calvin's system Christ is only the mirror of election for the elect. If Christ did not die for everyone, then looking to Christ cannot tell me whether he died for me.

Worse, Calvin taught that the reprobate can have an experience that looks and feels exactly like saving faith. "Experience shows that the reprobate are sometimes affected in a way so similar to the elect, that even in their own judgment there is no difference between them," he wrote, and he called this a "temporary faith."[75] The consequence for an ordinary believer is serious. If a man can believe, rejoice, and feel sure that he is saved, and still be reprobate, then his faith cannot assure him of anything. His only remaining evidence is his perseverance, which, as we saw in the last chapter, he cannot know until the end of his life.

The Bible does not leave God's children in that fog. It does not tell us to look for signs of a secret decree. It tells us to look at a public promise: "whosoever believeth in him should not perish, but have everlasting life" (John 3:16). Whosoever includes me. Believing is what I have done. Everlasting life is what God says I have. That is assurance that rests on God's word and not on my performance or on a decree I cannot see.

The Practical Test

A useful test of any doctrine is this: can you preach it to a sinner, pray it over a child, and rest on it when you are dying? The gospel as the Bible gives it passes that test. Christ died for your sins. Whosoever will may come. He that believeth hath everlasting life. The five points of Calvinism fail it. They cannot tell the sinner that Christ died for him, they cannot tell the parent that God desires the child's salvation, and they cannot tell the dying believer that his faith proves he is elect. A doctrine

[74]Calvin, *Institutes* 3.24.5.

[75]Calvin, *Institutes* 3.2.11.

that cannot be preached, prayed, or trusted in the moments that matter most is not the doctrine of the apostles.

CONCLUSION: JUST READ THE BIBLE

We began with a question: does a lost man have a genuine choice when God offers him salvation? Every point of Calvinism depends on the answer being no. We have seen that the Bible answers yes, over and over, from the garden to the last invitation of Revelation.

John 3:16

Most of us learned John 3:16 as children, and it answers the whole system in a single sentence. "For God so loved the world, that he gave his only begotten Son, that whosoever believeth in him should not perish, but have everlasting life" (John 3:16).

"God so loved the world." Not the elect only. That answers unconditional election. "He gave his only begotten Son." He gave him for the world. That answers limited atonement. "That whosoever believeth in him." Whosoever can believe. That answers total depravity and irresistible grace. "Should not perish, but have everlasting life." Everlasting, not dependent on how well we persevere. That answers the Calvinist version of perseverance. And the next verse closes the door on double predestination: "For God sent not his Son into the world to condemn the world; but that the world through him might be saved" (John 3:17).

When a child hears John 3:16, he does not imagine that "the world" means a select group chosen in eternity past. He takes it for what it says. That is exactly how God meant it to be taken. "Verily I say unto you, Except ye be converted, and become as little children, ye shall not enter into the kingdom of heaven" (Matt. 18:3).

A Few Rules That Protect Us

Most errors about salvation can be avoided with a few simple rules. First, consider the whole counsel of God. Read more than one verse and more than one passage. Second, never let an obscure passage overturn a clear one. Build on the clear verses,

and read the difficult ones in their light. Third, remember the character of God as the Bible reveals it. God loves the world. God is not willing that any should perish. God pleads with sinners to turn. Any system that makes him the author of their damnation has departed from the Bible. Fourth, ask whether a common man with childlike faith could get this from reading his Bible. If a doctrine can only be found by someone who has first been taught a philosophical system, it probably did not come from the Bible.

And fifth, be wary of any council of men that gathers outside the Bible to write rules that the Bible must then be forced to fit. That is what Rome did for centuries, and the Synod of Dort did the same. Calvinism does not let the Bible define its terms. It runs the Bible through TULIP.

The Crux of It All

We use the word *crux* to mean the center of something, the point on which everything turns. It comes from the Latin word for cross. That is fitting. The cross of Jesus Christ is the crux of history and the crux of this whole subject. When you lay your head on your pillow at night and think honestly about the cross, you know that Christ died for sinners, all of them. You know that the invitation is real. And you know that whosoever will may come.

The invitation stands for every reader. Those who have not come to Christ may come to him today, and those who have should tell others that the invitation is theirs as well. That is the gospel, and it is for everyone.

APPENDIX: GOD'S LOVE AND OFFER TO ALL

Throughout this book we have said that the Bible's invitations and promises are "all over the place." This appendix gathers the main passages in one place for study. The summaries are ours; read each passage in its setting and let it speak.

God Desires the Salvation of All

Ezekiel 18:23, 32 — God has no pleasure in the death of him that dieth; turn yourselves, and live.

Ezekiel 33:11 — As I live, I have no pleasure in the death of the wicked; turn ye, turn ye; why will ye die?

Matthew 23:37 — How often would I have gathered thy children together, and ye would not.

Luke 19:41–42 — The Lord wept over Jerusalem, wishing it had known the things of its peace.

1 Timothy 2:3–4 — God our Saviour will have all men to be saved and to come to the knowledge of the truth.

2 Peter 3:9. The Lord is not willing that any should perish, but that all should come to repentance.

Christ Died for All

Isaiah 53:6. The LORD hath laid on him the iniquity of us all.

John 1:29 — The Lamb of God, which taketh away the sin of the world.

John 3:16–17 — God so loved the world; the world through him might be saved.

John 4:42 — This is indeed the Christ, the Saviour of the world.

Romans 5:18 — The free gift came upon all men unto justification of life.

2 Corinthians 5:14–15, 19 — One died for all; God was in Christ, reconciling the world unto himself.

1 Timothy 2:5–6 — Christ Jesus gave himself a ransom for all.

1 Timothy 4:10 — The living God is the Saviour of all men, specially of those that believe.

Titus 2:11 — The grace of God that bringeth salvation hath appeared to all men.

Hebrews 2:9. Christ by the grace of God tasted death for every man.

2 Peter 2:1. False teachers deny the Lord that bought them.

1 John 2:2. He is the propitiation for our sins, and not for ours only, but also for the sins of the whole world.

1 John 4:14 — The Father sent the Son to be the Saviour of the world.

God Calls All to Repent and Believe

Deuteronomy 30:19 — I have set before you life and death; therefore choose life.

Joshua 24:15 — Choose you this day whom ye will serve.

Isaiah 45:22 — Look unto me, and be ye saved, all the ends of the earth.

Isaiah 55:1, 6–7 — Ho, every one that thirsteth; seek ye the LORD while he may be found.

Matthew 11:28 — Come unto me, all ye that labour and are heavy laden.

Mark 1:15 — Repent ye, and believe the gospel.

Mark 16:15–16 — Preach the gospel to every creature; he that believeth shall be saved.

John 7:37 — If any man thirst, let him come unto me, and drink.

John 12:32 — I, if I be lifted up from the earth, will draw all men unto me.

Acts 17:30 — God now commandeth all men every where to repent.

Romans 10:13 — Whosoever shall call upon the name of the Lord shall be saved.

Revelation 22:17 — Whosoever will, let him take the water of life freely.

Men Can Refuse God's Grace

Proverbs 1:24–26 — I have called, and ye refused; I have stretched out my hand, and no man regarded.

Luke 7:30 — The Pharisees and lawyers rejected the counsel of God against themselves.

John 5:40 — Ye will not come to me, that ye might have life.

Acts 7:51 — Ye do always resist the Holy Ghost: as your fathers did, so do ye.

Acts 13:46 — Seeing ye put it from you, and judge yourselves unworthy of everlasting life, lo, we turn to the Gentiles.

Hebrews 3:15 — To day if ye will hear his voice, harden not your hearts.

The Believer's Security Rests on God's Promise

John 3:36 — He that believeth on the Son hath everlasting life.

John 5:24 — He that heareth my word, and believeth on him that sent me, hath everlasting life.

John 10:28–29 — They shall never perish; no man is able to pluck them out of my Father's hand.

Romans 8:38–39 — Nothing shall be able to separate us from the love of God, which is in Christ Jesus.

Ephesians 1:13–14 — Sealed with that holy Spirit of promise, the earnest of our inheritance.

Ephesians 4:30 — Sealed unto the day of redemption.

1 John 5:13 — That ye may know that ye have eternal life.

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